# THY KINGDOM COME

VOLUME TWO

## The People

*A character and scripture companion for the drafting and revision of the novel. One dossier for everyone who matters in the 39th Trial, with room to find out who they are.*

DANY · OCTOBER 2026

NOTES

## ANYTHING THIS SPREAD STARTED AND DID NOT FINISH

VOLUME TWO

# Contents

*Five parts and the back matter. Each part opens with its own contents, and every dossier opens with a portrait.*


| | |
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# What this volume is

Volume One is the world: the scripture the Empire inherited, the history it rewrote, and the institutions, Dominions and Trials it built. This volume is the people who have to live inside all of that. It holds one dossier for every character with weight in the 39th Trial, from the woman at the kitchen table in Aurelia's outer districts to the man on the throne who taught himself never to be surprised.

A dossier here does what an entry in Volume One's people of the text does. It starts from what the files already say, keeps that separate from what's only inferred, and leaves most of the page ruled for you. The difference is that these people are yours. Nothing in a dossier outranks the manuscript, and where your files disagree with each other the page says so out loud instead of quietly picking a winner. Every major character gets a faith and scripture spread. It covers what they believe and who taught it to them, what the Temple teaches about someone like them, the biblical name or story they echo and where the echo breaks, the verses they'd quote and the ones nobody has ever read to them, and the exact pages in Volume One to go back to. The novel's religious line runs between faith the Temple can use and faith that answers to something it doesn't control. Every person in this book stands somewhere on that line, and the faith spread is where you find out where.

### WHAT IT ISN'T

It won't replace a cast list or a plot summary, and it won't answer anything for you. Where the files are silent the page is ruled, and the ruled space outranks anything printed near it.

### VOLUME ONE PAGES

Cross-references give the folio in Volume One, so "Vol. I, 393" means page 393 of The World Dossier, where Hannah, Abigail and Michal are.

### MARGINALIA

✤ *See also:* Volume One, the people of the text, page 369.

*"Belief has a cost and a teacher." Rule IV, from Volume One.*

# How a dossier works

Every dossier opens with a portrait page, a frame for a drawing, a reference image or Canva art, and the person's record underneath it. After that the pages run in the same order for everyone at the same length, so you can read across the cast and see where the Empire holds and where it's already coming apart.

### THE FULL DOSSIER, ABOUT SIXTEEN PAGES

1. The portrait and the record.
2. The Registry card and every name they answer to.
3. The years, set against the Empire's calendar.
4. Standing, the clerk's version and the true one.
5. Faith and scripture, what they believe and who taught it.
6. Faith and scripture, the text: the name, the verses, Volume One.
7. Body and fear, belief arc, power and people, voice and contradiction.
8. The working pages: the machinery around them, one excavated scene, one ordinary hour, one relationship from both sides, and a scene lab.

### THE SHORTER DOSSIERS

Thomas, Zion, Solomon, the House Aurem staff, Senior Minister Bell and the Prelate get about seven pages each, with the faith spread pressed onto a single page. Each Covenant Daughter gets about eight, with a page tracking her through the three phases.

### THE ONE RULE

No character gets a belief they've never paid for. If the creed page names a conviction, the contradiction page has to name what it cost.

### PHOTOCOPY FIRST

The working pages expect a second and third draft. Copy them before you fill them.

### MARGINALIA

✤ *See also:* The labels, on the next page.

VOL. I · 6–7

# Labels and sources

The page signals are the ones in Volume One. Quoted scripture sits behind a fine rule with its reference underneath. The heavy frame with the pink edge is always the Empire's reading and never the text's. A broken frame marks a real dispute among serious readers. Ruled space is yours.

| LABEL | WHAT IT MEANS HERE |
|---|---|
| (NO LABEL) | Your files say it, with the source tag in parentheses. Scripture and history with a reference are research, as in Volume One. |
| INTERPRETATION | A reading of a character or a passage, offered as a reading |
| CONTESTED | A real dispute about scripture among scholars or traditions |
| INFERENCE | A conclusion drawn from your files that they don't state |
| POSSIBLE | An idea worth considering, and not canon |
| OPEN QUESTION | Something only you can decide |
| CONFLICT | Two of your files disagree |
| SUPERSEDED | Older material that no longer controls |
| DECIDED | A call you've made. Canon from here on. |

| TAG | SOURCE |
|---|---|
| FR 0–44 | Final Rulings. These outrank everything. |
| TL · TR · DOM · MEN · CR | Timeline · Trials · Dominions · Men in the Empire · The Crownward |
| DR3 · WR · AM | Draft Three (chapter one) · Writing Rules · the old Companion |
| RULING | A call you've made in conversation, logged in the back of this volume |

# The cast at a glance

TKC: TL · TR · MEN · CR · FR 0 · FR 11 · RULING

Ages are at the opening of the 39th Trial, summer 2104.

| NAME | WHO | AGE | DOSSIER |
|---|---|---|---|
| CELESTE PARISH | Eden's grandmother, Unbound, head of household | 69 | I · full |
| EDEN SELAH OSEI | Covenant Daughter of Aurem | 21 | I · full |
| MIRIAM OSEI | Eden's mother, gone since 2090 | 42 | I · full |
| THOMAS OSEI | Eden's father, gone since 2084 | | I · short |
| LEAH OSEI | Eden's younger sister, a Commonwife | 20 | I · full |
| ZION OSEI | Eden's brother, labor track | 18 | I · short |
| SOLOMON OSEI | Eden's youngest brother | 16 | I · short |
| HANNAH | House Mother, House Aurem | | II · full |
| NAOMI | Hannah's daughter, in Vowed education | | II · full |
| MIRIELLE · GAVIN · ABIGAIL | Coordinator · stylist · Debate and Protocol Advisor | | II · short |
| SENIOR MINISTER BELL | The Aurelia Temple | | II · short |

**DECIDED** Zion is eighteen (**Ruling**) and Solomon is sixteen. Miriam's age follows from her birth in 2062 (**TL**). The blanks are yours.

TKC: TR · TL · CR · RULING · FR 33

# THE CAST AT A GLANCE, CONTINUED

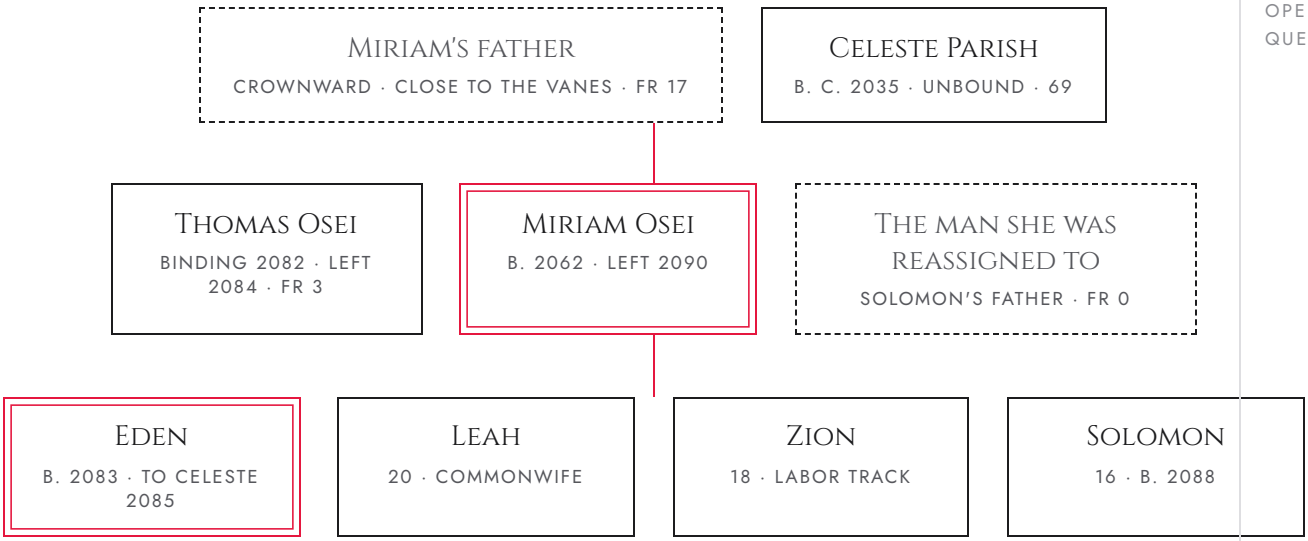
| NAME | WHO | AGE | DOSSIER |
|---|---|---|---|
| DELPHINE FONTENOT | Gulf · Port Seraphine | 22 | III |
| MAREN COLE | Ardenne · Ashford | 23 | III |
| CORINNE VALE | Meridian · Blessed Shore | 22 | III |
| CALLA MERRITT | Vane · Saint Meridian | 21 | III |
| NADIA ORIN | Irongate · Iron Benediction | 20 | III |
| RUTH GIDEON | Heartland · Providence Cross | 22 | III |
| DELIA CROSS | Red Earth · Canaan's Gate | 24 | III |
| VIVIENNE HALE | Lone · Covenant Basin | 23 | III |
| PETRA SOLANO | Mountain · Crestfall | 22 | III |
| ZARA VOSS | Sable · Sable Reach | 21 | III |
| SERA MONTOYA | Pacific · Westhold | 24 | III |
| DORIAN VANE | Emperor since 2085 | 59 | IV · full |
| LYRIS VANE | Empress, from Mountain | 58 | IV · full |
| JUDAH ELIJAH VANE | Crown Heir | 25 | IV · full |
| AZRAEL VANE | "Deceased" since 2100 | 27 | IV · full |
| THE PRELATE | Head of the Crownward Vowed | 67 | IV · short |

Calla's surname is Merritt (**Ruling**). The Prelate's working name is Aurelia, which is POSSIBLE, and she's never Huldah or Naomi (**FR 33**).

# The household, drawn

TKC: TL · FR 0 · FR 3 · FR 4–5 · FR 17 · MEN

OPEN QUESTION




Eden went to Celeste alone in 2085. Leah, Zion and Solomon came together in 2090, when Miriam left (**FR 4–5**). Celeste's reclassification absorbed all four as her dependents (**FR 2, 10**). **INFERENCE** Leah was born in 2084 and Zion in 2085. Zion was conceived before Thomas left and born after (**FR 0**), which fits eighteen if his birthday falls after chapter one.

**WHO ELSE BELONGS ON THIS TREE: CELESTE'S MOTHER, HER GRANDMOTHER, LEAH'S HUSBAND, THE THREE CELESTE BURIED**

FINAL RULINGS

RULING

DECIDED

# The canon this volume runs on

Every dossier was written against these. Where a file disagrees, the page prints the file's version as SUPERSEDED and moves on.

| RULING | WHAT IT FIXES |
|---|---|
| FR 0 | Solomon's father is the man Miriam was reassigned to after Thomas left. Zion is Thomas's. |
| FR 3 | Thomas left voluntarily in 2084, for another Dominion, another woman, another life. |
| FR 4–6 | Eden went to Celeste alone in 2085. The younger three came in 2090. Miriam left all four and went alone. |
| FR 11–16 | What each child saw on the day she left, what they were told, and the 2094 letter nobody received. Celeste has no proof Miriam is alive. |
| FR 17–18 | Miriam's father, his household, and why she came back |
| FR 19–25 | What the Trials do with all twelve women, and the rules around the Declaration |
| FR 26–34 | Hannah's career, Naomi, the 2085 cohort, and the Prelate's name |
| FR 35–44 | The House of Vane, the removed heir, and the documents |
| RULING | Zion is eighteen. Solomon is sixteen. Leah is younger than Eden and sat for an assessment. Dorian is fifty-nine. Calla's surname is Merritt. |

Every ruling is printed in full in the back matter, with the conflicts it settles.

# Where the faith pages point

VOL. I · 382 · 417 · 509–518 · 521–530

Each faith spread ends with a box of Volume One pages. These are the ones the cast comes back to most.

| FOR | GO TO VOLUME ONE |
|---|---|
| A CHARACTER'S BIBLICAL NAME | The names in the cast, 417, and echoes, labeled, 419 |
| THE WOMEN THEY'RE COMPARED TO | The people of the text, from Eve on 383 |
| THE MEN THEY'RE COMPARED TO | The founders, 397. David, 399. Kingmakers, prophets and priests, 400. |
| WHAT THE TEMPLE TEACHES | The official religion, 494. The founding texts, 496. |
| WHAT PEOPLE ACTUALLY PRACTICE | Lived religion, 513–518 |
| WHERE A WOMAN SITS | The designations, 506. Being sorted, 508. The Binding, 510. |
| THE HOUSEHOLD ON PAPER | Commonwives and the Arrangement, 512. Four households, 514. |
| A MAN'S PLACE | Men, labor and the economy, 507 |
| THE PRAYER THE BOOK IS NAMED FOR | The Lord's Prayer, from 428 |
| PASSAGES THE EMPIRE USES AND BURIES | Passages put to work, 440. Passages kept quiet, 442. |
| A CHARACTER'S HOME | The twelve Dominions, 536–555 |

THE VOLUME ONE PAGE I KEEP GOING BACK TO WHILE I DRAFT, AND WHY

WRITING

FROM THE FACING PAGE

**THE VOLUME ONE PAGE I KEEP GOING BACK TO WHILE I DRAFT, AND WHY**

# Before you begin

YOURS

Answer these once, in ink, before you open a single dossier. The point is a record of where you started with these people.

### THE CHARACTER I UNDERSTAND LEAST, AND WHAT I'M AFRAID I'LL FIND

### THE CHARACTER I'D DEFEND TO ANYONE, AND THE ONE I'D NEVER FORGIVE

### WHO IN THIS BOOK BELIEVES MOST HONESTLY, AND WHO BELIEVES MOST USEFULLY

**DECIDED** **DATE**

NOTES

## ANYTHING THIS SPREAD STARTED AND DID NOT FINISH

I

PART ONE · ◈

# The Parish Household

*One small house in Aurelia's outer district, a grandmother on the authority line in all but name, and four children who arrived in two waves.*


| | |
|---|---|
| i · The household as a teaching | 016 |
| Celeste Parish | 020 |
| Eden Selah Osei | 043 |
| Miriam Osei | 065 |
| Thomas Osei | 084 |
| Leah Osei | 089 |
| Zion Osei | 103 |
| Solomon Osei | 108 |
| Working questions for the household | 113 |

TL | MEN | FR 0–18

### THE TWO WAVES

2085, Eden alone, about two years old. 2090, Leah, Zion and Solomon together, after Miriam left (FR 4–5).

### THE HOUSEHOLD ON PAPER

Unbound, reclassified after six years, with a young man on the authority line (Vol. I, 529).

### MARGINALIA

✣ *See also:* Vol. I, the household on paper, 514. Aurem, 520.

# The household as a teaching

Everything Eden carries into the Crownward was assembled in one house, and most of it at one kitchen table. Celeste taught there. Leah comes back to it twice a week to breathe. Zion signs the forms that come to it, and Solomon is being coached at it on how much of his own mind to show. Miriam left it, and Thomas never lived in it (TL, MEN, FR 4–5).

The Empire reads this household as a set of failures on paper: an Unbound woman with no husband, a mother whose registration was deactivated, a father who relocated, a daughter under Temple review. Read the same facts from inside the house and they're a faith that has survived an institution by never handing it everything. The dossiers in this part are written from inside the house. They're also written after the Final Rulings, which changed this family more than any other. Thomas left voluntarily, and the paperwork that said so was accurate (FR 3). Celeste has no proof Miriam is alive (FR 16). Eden grew up as Celeste's child, and the younger three remember arriving into a house that was already running (FR 5). Solomon's father is someone else (FR 0). Any older page that says otherwise is SUPERSEDED.

# THE DAY SHE LEFT

TKC: FR 11–15 · TL

**CONTENT NOTE** A mother leaving her children. Nothing graphic.

Four children were in or near the house when Miriam left in 2090, and each kept a different piece of it. The rulings fix what each one has.

| CHILD | AGE THEN | WHAT THEY HAVE | SOURCE |
|---|---|---|---|
| EDEN | 7 | Being given a task, to take Zion outside. Fourteen years understanding that the task was to get her out of the room. | FR 11, 13 |
| LEAH | 6 | She watched her pack. She remembers a decision more than a disappearance, which is why she's the angriest and why she defends Miriam to the others. | FR 11, 14 |
| ZION | 4 | The yard. He's never mentioned it. | FR 11, 13 |
| SOLOMON | 2 | Nothing he can know is his own | FR 11 |

| | |
|---|---|
| WHAT THEY WERE TOLD | "She's coming back." It held about a year, then stopped being said, and nothing ever replaced it (**FR 12**). |
| WHY NOBODY HEARD | Being unreachable wasn't selective. No version existed where she was hidden from her father and available to her children (**FR 15**). |
| THE LETTER | One attempt, in 2094, intercepted before it reached Celeste. Celeste never knew it existed. Who intercepted it is still open (**FR 16**). |

### THE FIRST EVENING THE THREE OF THEM SPENT IN CELESTE'S HOUSE, AND WHO COOKED

WRITING

FROM THE FACING PAGE

**THE FIRST EVENING THE THREE OF THEM SPENT IN CELESTE'S HOUSE, AND WHO COOKED**

# The household's years

TKC: TL · MEN · FR 0 · FR 3–5 · FR 16 · RULING

| YEAR | IN THE HOUSE | SOURCE |
|---|---|---|
| c. 2035 | Celeste born. She's about nine in 2044 when the signs change. | TL |
| 2062 | Miriam born to Celeste, who raises her alone, Unbound | TL |
| 2071 | Celeste settles in Aurelia for good after years moving between Dominions | TL |
| 2082 | Miriam, twenty, is Bound to Thomas Osei as a Commonwife | TL, FR 1 |
| 2083 | Eden born, Celeste present | TL |
| 2084 | Leah born. Thomas leaves, voluntarily. Miriam reassigned to another man's household. | FR 0, FR 3, INFERENCE |
| 2085 | Zion born. Eden goes to Celeste, alone. | FR 0, FR 4, INFERENCE |
| 2088 | Solomon born to the man Miriam was reassigned to | FR 0, FR 11 |
| 2090 | Miriam leaves. Leah, Zion and Solomon come to Celeste. The reclassification is filed. | TL, FR 5 |
| 2094 | Miriam's one letter, intercepted | FR 16 |
| 2096 | The reclassification is approved. Celeste doesn't speak for three days. | TL |
| 2101 | Eden designates, highest score in Aurem's history, and is flagged | TL |
| 2102 | Leah Bound, at eighteen | MEN, INFERENCE |
| 2103 | Zion's Speaking and Covenant Declaration, at eighteen | MEN, Ruling |
| 2104 | Eden self-nominates, places first, and leaves for the Crownward | TL, TR |

**CONFLICT** The timeline has Miriam born "in Aurelia" in 2062 and Celeste settling there in 2071.
**INFERENCE** Both hold if Celeste was in the city in 2062 without settling.

TKC: TL · DR3 · DOM · AM

VOL. I · 482 · 513 · 529

PORTRAIT · CELESTE PARISH · SIXTY-NINE · DRAW, PASTE OR PIN

PART I · DOSSIER 1 · ◈

# CELESTE

*Everything Eden knows about faith she learned at this woman's kitchen table. Everything she knows about hiding she learned there too, and only one of those was taught on purpose.*

**ON THE RECORD**

Celeste Parish, sixty-nine. Unbound her whole life. Head of a reclassified household in Aurelia's outer district, and the oldest person in the cast (**TL**). About nine when they changed the signs.

**STILL OPEN**

Where she was born, who Miriam's father is to her, the three people she's buried the old way, and the second name she gave Eden.

# The Registry card

TKC: TL · DR3 · FR 2 · FR 10

VOL. I · 505 · 529

## Household Record

REGISTRY · AUREM · H-1

AS THE MINISTRY HOLDS IT · RECLASSIFIED 2096

| | |
|---|---|
| NAME OF RECORD | *PARISH, Celeste* |
| DESIGNATION | *Unbound · held for life · no Binding on record* |
| BORN | *c. 2035 (INFERENCE from her age)* |
| RESIDENCE | *Aurelia, outer district · settled 2071* |
| HOUSEHOLD | *single-family unit, under her registration* |
| DEPENDENTS | *Eden, Leah, Zion, Solomon Osei, entered 2085 and 2090* |
| ADULT MALE AUTHORITY | *"deceased" · returned circled · Zion Osei* |

UNBOUND

| NAME | WHO USES IT | WHAT IT DOES TO HER |
|---|---|---|
| MOTHER PARISH | Minister Bell, the Temple | Respect she didn't ask for, from an institution she doesn't trust (**DR3**) |
| GRANDMAMA | The children | The only title she earned instead of survived (**DR3**) |
| HEAD OF HOUSEHOLD | The Ministry, since 2096 | Six years of paperwork to be called this on one line (**TL**) |

WRITING

FROM THE FACING PAGE

## THE NAME HER OWN MOTHER CALLED HER, AND THE LAST PERSON ALIVE WHO USES IT

# Her years against the Empire's

TKC: TL · DOM · DR3 · FR 4 · FR 16–17

VOL. I · 475 · 482

| YEAR | AGE | HER LIFE | THE EMPIRE THAT YEAR |
|---|---|---|---|
| c. 2035 | 0 | Born. Where is open. | Elias wins his Senate seat |
| 2044 | 9 | Watches her own grandmother cry when the signs change (TL) | The Dominion Act. Atlanta becomes Aurelia. |
| | | Her mother taken through a Commonwife marriage (TL) | |
| 2062 | 27 | Miriam born. Raised alone, Unbound (TL). | Crest takes the throne. Quotas go Empire-wide. |
| 2071 | 36 | Settles in Aurelia for good (TL) | |
| 2082 | 47 | Performs the Salt Ceremony the night before Miriam's Binding (DOM) | |
| 2085 | 50 | Takes Eden, about two (TL, FR 4) | Crest dies. Dorian takes the throne. |
| 2090 | 55 | Miriam leaves. Three more children arrive. She files. (TL) | |
| 2096 | 61 | Reclassification approved. Three days without speaking. (TL) | |
| 2101 | 66 | Eden's score. She holds still, then goes back to the stove (TL) | |
| 2104 | 69 | The ten dollars, the cleared shelf, the real name of the city (DR3, TL) | The 39th Trial |

**INFERENCE** She's about nine in 2044, so born around 2035, and the timeline's "mid thirties" in 2071 agrees.

### THE YEAR SHE NEVER TALKS ABOUT, AND WHY

WRITING

FROM THE FACING PAGE

## THE YEAR SHE NEVER TALKS ABOUT, AND WHY

# The clerk's version and the true one

TKC: TL · DR3 · DOM

VOL. I · 505 · 521 · 529

| | |
|---|---|
| ON THE LEDGER | Unbound, sixty-nine, head of a single-family household in the outer district. Never Bound, so never widowed in law. A woman with no husband, no office and no standing beyond what the reclassification granted her in writing (**TL**). |
| IN THE WIDOWS' ROW | She sits in the row reserved for widows at Temple, and nobody has ever asked her to move. Minister Bell has known her thirty-four years, eaten her sweet potato pie at harvest suppers, and called every winter when the Temple needed coats repaired. He greets her with both hands out. She looks at their joined hands and answers "Morning," and he keeps smiling (**DR3**). |
| THE SIX-YEAR FILING | When Miriam left in 2090 she filed to reclassify the household under her own registration. Approval took six years, because she had to prove the arrangement was permanent, which meant proving her daughter wasn't coming back. She put on her one good blouse, went downtown, and said what she needed to say (**TL**). |
| THE AUTHORITY LINE | A form for Solomon came demanding an adult male authority. She wrote "deceased" on the line. It came back with the word circled and a request for the next adult male, and Zion, at eighteen, signed. She hadn't wanted him to (**DR3**). |
| INFERENCE | She has no office, no money and no husband, and she may be the most powerful person in her district. |

**WHAT THIS HOUSEHOLD LIVES ON, WHO EARNS IT, AND WHAT IT DOESN'T COVER**

WRITING

FROM THE FACING PAGE

**WHAT THIS HOUSEHOLD LIVES ON, WHO EARNS IT, AND WHAT IT DOESN'T COVER**

# What She Believes

TKC: DOM · DR3 · TL · AM · FR 16

VOL. I · 509 · 513 · 518

Celeste is the most religious person in the book and the least Imperial (AM). Those don't pull against each other for her, and the pages where a reader feels that are the engine of the Parish house.

| | |
|---|---|
| WHAT SHE BELIEVES | INFERENCE Keep part of yourself unregistered. It's what the salt water is for, what the second name is for, and what "morning" is instead of an answer. Faith can survive an institution by not handing it everything. |
| WHO TAUGHT HER | OPEN QUESTION Her grandmother, who cried at the signs (TL), or her mother, who lost her name to a Commonwife marriage? The files don't say who first put scripture in her hands. |
| WHAT SHE CAN RECITE | All of it, including the Covenant of Purpose (AM). INFERENCE Fluency is her camouflage. |
| WHAT SHE TRUSTS WHEN FRIGHTENED | Her hands. She prays from the moment they leave the house, thumb against her first knuckle, one tap per petition (DR3). When Eden paid the ten dollars she didn't pray about it. She cleared a shelf (DR3). |
| WHAT SHE'D BE ARRESTED FOR | The Salt Ceremony, which the Empire doesn't know exists, and burying the dead the old way (DOM). The real name of the city, said out loud to Eden the night before she leaves (TL). |

### WHAT THE TEMPLE TEACHES ABOUT A WOMAN LIKE HER

An Unbound woman is "difficult and surveilled" (TL), and every household form asks for a man (DR3). POSSIBLE The Temple seats her in the widows' row and preaches 1 Timothy 5.5, the "widow indeed" who "trusteth in God, and continueth in supplications and prayers." It honors her and files her in one gesture, without ever saying she was never anyone's widow.

SUPERSEDED An earlier round had Celeste knowing Miriam was alive and hiding it. She has no proof Miriam is alive (FR 16), so her silence about her daughter is grief with no information in it.

WRITING

FROM THE FACING PAGE

**THE ONE PIECE OF IMPERIAL DOCTRINE SHE HALF BELIEVES, AND HATES THAT SHE DOES**

# The text

| | |
|---|---|
| HER NAME | *Celeste* is from the Latin *caelestis*, "heavenly." It has no biblical source. She's the only person in the house without scripture in her name, and the one who taught the others theirs. |
| LOIS · 2 TIMOTHY 1.5 | **POSSIBLE** Paul names Timothy's grandmother: the "unfeigned faith... which dwelt first in thy grandmother Lois." A grandmother's faith passed down a household. **Where it breaks:** Lois's faith is honored by an apostle in writing. Celeste's is kept off every record on purpose. |
| NAOMI · RUTH 1–4 | **POSSIBLE** A woman who's buried what she loved and sends the younger one where the future is. **Where it breaks:** Naomi sends Ruth to a man. Celeste sends Eden toward one and arms her against him in the same sentence (TL). |
| RIZPAH · 2 SAMUEL 21 | **POSSIBLE** She guards the bodies of her sons on a rock from harvest until rain, until the king buries them properly. Celeste has buried three people the old way (DOM). **Where it breaks:** Rizpah's vigil is public and shames a king. Celeste's is arranged so no king ever hears of it. |

| SHE'D QUOTE | NEVER READ TO HER IN THE TEMPLE |
|---|---|
| "Ye are the salt of the earth" (Matt 5.13), at a Salt Ceremony | Isaiah 10.1–2, woe to those who decree unrighteous decrees "that widows may be their prey" |
| "How shall we sing the LORD's song in a strange land?" (Ps 137.4) | Luke 18.1–8, the widow who wears down a judge who "feared not God, neither regarded man" |
| "Pray to thy Father which is in secret" (Matt 6.6) | |

> **VOLUME ONE**
>
> Ruth and Naomi, 391 and 109. The unnamed, and two widows, 388. The women who ran things, with the widows of Acts 6, 395. Deuteronomy 6, the household is the school, 334. Lived religion and the Salt Ceremony, 498. Faith that isn't performance, 503. Living memory, 467.

2 TIM 1.5

RUTH 1–4

2 SAM 21.8–14

MATT 5.13

PS 137.4

MATT 6.6

ISA 10.1–2

LUKE 18.1–8

TKC: DR3 · TL · DOM

# Body and fear

Sixty-nine years of holding still in rooms that were assessing her. The manuscript already knows what that looks like.

| | |
|---|---|
| WHAT THE RECORD SHOWS | A cane she didn't need last summer. This year she says people move faster when you carry one, and both reasons are true (**DR3**). Back straight in the widows' row, gloved hands over the handle. Three days of not speaking after the reclassification cleared (**TL**). |
| WHAT POLITENESS COSTS | Bell takes her hand and she looks at their joined hands before she answers. The cane shifts against the floor when he says Eden's name (**DR3**). **INTERPRETATION** Her body objects about half a second before her manners arrive, and only Eden can read it. |
| THE HEAT | Aurem summer "sits on your back from May through October and expects you to carry it" (**DOM**). She's carried sixty-nine of them. |
| THE THREE BURIALS | She's buried three people the old way and intends to be buried that way herself (**DOM**). |
| WHAT SHE'S AFRAID IS TRUE | **INFERENCE** Teaching a girl to keep part of herself unregistered might only be a slower loss. Miriam had the salt water and left anyway. If that's true, she's sent Eden to the Crownward with a hymn instead of armor. |

### WHAT HER BODY DOES THAT SHE HAS NO IDEA EDEN CAN READ

### THE NIGHT SHE WAS MOST AFRAID, AND WHAT SHE DID INSTEAD OF SAYING SO

# Belief arc

TKC: TL · DR3 · FR 16

YOURS

The first two stations are printed from your files, because she's already lived them. The last two are the book. The oldest person in the house is the one most likely to be asked to change her mind, and she's had the least practice.

| STATION | WHAT SHE BELIEVES | WHAT CRACKS IT, AND WHAT SHE DOES | CH. |
|---|---|---|---|
| I · Before Aurelia | Refusing the Empire's terms is survivable if you're careful. She stays Unbound and moves between Dominions rather than settle where a Binding could find her (**TL**). | Miriam, raised to refuse everything, takes the first Binding offered at twenty and believes she loves him (**TL**) | |
| II · After Miriam | **INFERENCE** Keep part of yourself unregistered, and teach it earlier and harder. | Eden pays ten dollars to be judged. Celeste names what it bought and clears a shelf by midnight (**DR3**). | |
| III · In this book | | | |
| IV · On the last page | | | |

### WHO NOTICES FIRST THAT SHE'S CHANGED, AND WHAT THEY SEE

### THE SCENE WHERE THE CRACK SHOWS, AND WHO'S IN THE KITCHEN WHEN IT DOES

TKC: TL · DR3 · MEN · FR 11–17

# Who she can move, and who can move her

| PERSON | WHAT PASSES BETWEEN THEM | LEVERAGE |
|---|---|---|
| EDEN | Everything she knows about faith, and the real name of the city (**TL**) | Eden's. She left anyway, and Celeste helped her go. |
| LEAH | Comes to the kitchen twice a week under cover of helping with Solomon (**MEN**) | Leah's husband, and the quarterly assessment |
| ZION · 18 | Signed the form she didn't want him to sign (**DR3**). Promised Eden he'd look after her (**TL**). | The Empire's, through him. He's the man on the form now. |
| SOLOMON · 16 | She's coaching him on how much of himself to show (**MEN**) | A Crown education officer who hasn't knocked yet |
| MIRIAM | A name she doesn't speak lightly (**TL**). No proof she's alive (**FR 16**). | Miriam's, by being absent |
| MINISTER BELL | Thirty-four years, pie and coats, and a sponsorship he wouldn't give (**DR3**) | His, formally. She has thirty-four years of receipts. |
| MIRIAM'S FATHER | **INFERENCE** The man from the unregistered ceremony that he survived, and "it was not an oversight" (**FR 17**) | |

### WHO IN THE DISTRICT OWES HER, AND WHAT SHE'S NEVER CALLED IN

### WHO SHE PRAYS FOR THAT NOBODY WOULD GUESS

# Her voice

TKC: DR3 · TL

Hers is the most distinct voice in the manuscript: short, dry, flat, and almost never the answer to the question asked. Lines already on the page are printed. Keep the rhythm when you add to them.

| | |
|---|---|
| ON THE PAGE | "You need to stop bending that card. You distracting me." Without turning her head (**DR3**). |
| TO A MINISTER | "Morning." To a man of thirty-four years who's just said what a joy it is to see her (**DR3**). |
| TO THE HOUSE | "Well. The House calls whom it calls." (**DR3**) |
| TEASING | "You like seeing how close you can get." "To what?" "My cane." (**DR3**) |
| THE RECEIPT | "You paid ten dollars for the right to be judged by people who already decided what you are." (**DR3**) |
| GRADING | "Passing ain't the same as placing." (**DR3**) |
| THE LAST NIGHT | "Remember what I told you about the real name of this city." (**TL**) |

**INFERENCE** Four words where six would do. She answers the second question, not the first, says the hard sentence flat and stops, and never raises her voice in a building the Empire owns.

### LINES ONLY SHE WOULD SAY. WRITE TEN, KEEP THREE.

### WORDS SHE WON'T USE, AND WHY

WRITING

FROM THE FACING PAGE

**LINES ONLY SHE WOULD SAY. WRITE TEN, KEEP THREE.**

# The contradiction

TKC: DR3 · TL · DOM

Your files contain hers twice, and the cost is on record both times.

| | |
|---|---|
| WHAT SHE BELIEVES AND BREAKS | **INFERENCE** You don't hand the Empire anything it hasn't already taken. She told Eden exactly what the ten dollars bought, and by midnight she'd cleared a shelf for the study materials (**DR3**). Knowing better, she helped. |
| WHAT IT COST, THE FIRST TIME | She raised Miriam to refuse everything, and Miriam accepted a Binding at twenty (**TL**). The Salt Ceremony didn't save her (**DOM**). |
| WHAT IT MAY COST NOW | She's helped the second one out the door toward the same institution in a better dress. Whatever comes after the Trials, she signed for it too. |

### WHY SHE HELPED ANYWAY, IN HER WORDS AND NOT YOURS

### THE SCENE WHERE THE CONTRADICTION LANDS ON HER, AND THE CHAPTER

DR3 MEN DOM

**FIVE PRESSURES**

The authority line, Solomon's scores, Leah's timeline, the Temple and Aurem.

**WHAT ISN'T ON THE LIST**

Miriam, and every one of the five runs around the hole she left.

**MARGINALIA**

# The machinery around her

Five systems press on a sixty-nine-year-old woman with no legal standing, and none of them asks her permission. Read this page, then turn it while it's still loud.

The authority line comes first. Every form that matters asks for an adult male. She wrote "deceased" and it came back circled (DR3). Her authority is real inside the house and gone at the counter, and the Empire will keep sending her paper that says so. Solomon's scores come next. A common boy whose scores come back exceptional gets a visit from a Crown education officer within three months, and refusing the offer routes him to the worst labor for life (MEN). Two informal notes are already filed, and she's coaching him to show less (MEN). Leah sits under the Commonwife timeline, nearly two years Bound with no pregnancy and a Vowed officer making comments (MEN). Celeste can feed her and can't protect her. The Temple she attends anyway knows her best and priced her most exactly. Thirty-four years of pie and coats bought her a seat in the widows' row and no sponsorship (DR3). And Aurem itself, the Dominion with the highest Commonwife rate, made marriage look like the highest honor available on purpose (DOM).

INTERPRETATION Staying Unbound in Aurem has never been a private choice. She's been making a public statement for fifty years.

✤ *See also:* Vol. I, the forms, 490. Men and labor, 492.

# The one good blouse

TKC: TL

WRITING

Anywhere else it would have been called an adoption. Here it took six years, because approval meant proving on paper that her daughter wasn't coming back. She put on her one good blouse, went downtown, said what she needed to say, and didn't speak for three days after it was approved. Eden was in the room when she got home. Celeste held her face in both hands and said nothing (TL).

**1 · WHAT SHE SAID AT THE COUNTER. WRITE THE SENTENCE THAT ENDS A DAUGHTER ON PAPER, AND WHAT THE CLERK DID WITH HIS PEN.**

**2 · THE THREE DAYS. THE HOUSE KEEPS RUNNING. WHO COOKS, WHO READS HER SILENCE, AND WHAT A THIRTEEN-YEAR-OLD EDEN DECIDES IT MEANS.**

**3 · WHERE THIS SHOWS UP LATER, AND WHAT SHE DOES DIFFERENTLY BECAUSE OF IT**

WRITING

FREEWRITE

# Write her alone

Ten minutes of Celeste in that house with nobody in it. No grandchildren to be steady for, no minister to be polite to, no forms. She's performed composure for fifty years, and there's a version of her only an empty kitchen has met.

If you stall, reach for one: what she does with the cane when nobody can see · the chair she never sits in · what she cooks for herself and whether she eats it · what she says out loud to God when it's only God · the drawer nothing's come out of in fourteen years · what she does with Miriam's name · the sound of the house at nine at night · what she's still angry about from 2044.

**WRITE**

Anything here that surprised you is canon unless you cross it out. Date it.

# Celeste and Miriam

TKC: TL · FR 3 · FR 6–9 · FR 15–18

**CONTENT NOTE** A daughter's disappearance and a mother's grief.

### WHAT CELESTE HAS

Miriam took the first Binding offered and was unrecognizable within four years (TL). Her registration was deactivated in 2090 with no forwarding Dominion (TL). One promise to come back, then nothing, and no letter ever reached the house (FR 12, 16).

### WHAT CELESTE THINKS HAPPENED TO HER DAUGHTER

### WHAT HAPPENED

After Thomas left, Miriam was reassigned to another man's household (FR 0). She left her children with Celeste to protect them from that household and from the search (FR 6, 9). She went looking for her father, who was close to the Vanes, and being unreachable wasn't something she chose (FR 15, 17).

### WHAT MIRIAM WOULD SAY ABOUT HER MOTHER'S TEACHING, GIVEN THE CHANCE

### IF MIRIAM COMES BACK, WHO'S IN THE ROOM, AND WHAT'S COOKING

WRITING

SCENE LAB

# Put pressure on the belief

Take one thing Celeste believes and build the room that tests it. Fill the short lines fast. They're scaffolding, not prose. Her beliefs are sixty years old and have never met anyone who could out-argue them, so find that person.

**THE SCAFFOLD**

The belief, in her words

Who can challenge it

A room she can't leave

Who else is listening, and for whom

What the other person wants

What she wants

What she says, four words or fewer

What she won't say

**ROUGH THE SCENE. DIALOGUE ONLY IS FINE.**

☐ POSSIBLE ☐ OPEN QUESTION ☐ DECIDED

LOG NO.

DATE

WRITING

FROM THE FACING PAGE

**ROUGH THE SCENE. DIALOGUE ONLY IS FINE.**

NOTES

## ANYTHING CELESTE'S DOSSIER STARTED AND DIDN'T FINISH



PORTRAIT · EDEN SELAH OSEI · TWENTY-ONE · COVENANT DAUGHTER OF AUREM

TKC: TL · TR · DR3 · CR · MEN

VOL. I · 563 · 565 · 575

PART I · DOSSIER 2 · ◈

# EDEN

*Raised by her grandmother in the outer districts on a faith assembled at a kitchen table. Self-nominated, first in Aurem, and flagged since she was eighteen.*

### ON THE RECORD

Eden Selah Osei, twenty-one. Covenant Daughter of Aurem for the 39th Trial, the first Aurem candidate ever to enter by self-nomination (**TL**). Placed first in the Regional Assessment. Wins (**TR**).

### STILL OPEN

The house name Celeste gave her, the four words she says to Sera, the three things Lyris tells her, and what she believes on the last page.

TKC: TL · TR · DR3 · DOM

VOL. I · 523 · 563

# The file that opens before she speaks

## Designation Record

REGISTRY · AUREM · 2101

CROWN ADMINISTRATIVE BUILDING · AURELIA · ASSESSED BY A VOWED OFFICER

| | |
|---|---|
| NAME OF RECORD | *OSEI, Eden Selah* |
| BORN | *2083 · Aurelia* |
| HOUSEHOLD | *Parish, Celeste · guardian of record since 2085* |
| SCORE | *highest in the Dominion's recorded history* |
| FLAG, 2101 | *"Exceptional intellect. Monitor closely."* |
| FLAG, 2104 | *"Selected for Trial. Monitor closely."* |
| ENTRY | *independent submission · ten dollars · red card* |

MONITOR CLOSELY

| NAME | WHO USES IT | WHAT IT DOES TO HER |
|---|---|---|
| EDEN SELAH OSEI | The Ministry, on paper | A file that's already open before she speaks (TL) |
| COVENANT DAUGHTER OF AUREM | The Broadcast and the Boulevard boards | A Dominion of millions standing behind one name (TR) |
| EDEN | Celeste, at the stove | The only room where she isn't being scored |
| THE HOUSE NAME | Celeste, inside the house only (TL) | |

WRITING

FROM THE FACING PAGE

**THE HOUSE NAME. WRITE IT, AND WHAT CELESTE SAID WHEN SHE GAVE IT.**

TKC: TL · TR · CR · MEN · FR 4 · FR 11 · RULING

VOL. I · 476

# Her years against the Empire's

| YEAR | AGE | HER LIFE | THE EMPIRE THAT YEAR |
|---|---|---|---|
| 2083 | 0 | Born in Aurelia, Celeste present (TL) | Crest's last years. The Trials are nineteen cycles old. |
| 2084 | 1 | Thomas leaves (FR 3) | |
| 2085 | 2 | Goes to Celeste, alone, and stays (FR 4) | Crest dies. Dorian takes the throne. The Trial is cancelled. |
| 2090 | 7 | Given a task the day Miriam leaves, to take Zion outside (FR 11) | |
| 2096 | 13 | In the room when Celeste comes home from downtown (TL) | |
| 2100 | 17 | | Azrael "dies" |
| 2101 | 18 | Designation. Highest score in Aurem's history, and flagged that day (TL) | |
| 2101–04 | 18–21 | Studies the Anointed Court wives by name, relationship and preference (CR) | |
| 2104 | 21 | Six months of paperwork. Self-nominates in May. First in the Regional Assessment. (TL) | The 39th Trial |

INFERENCE Six months of paperwork finished by early May means she started in late 2103, around the time Zion turned eighteen.

### THE THREE YEARS SHE'D NAME IF ASKED WHEN HER LIFE CHANGED, AND WHAT SHE WAS DOING IN EACH

**THE THREE YEARS SHE'D NAME IF ASKED WHEN HER LIFE CHANGED, AND WHAT SHE WAS DOING IN EACH**

TKC: TL · TR · DR3 · CR

VOL. I · 521 · 523 · 563 · 565

# The clerk's version and the true one

| | |
|---|---|
| ON THE LEDGER | Covenant Daughter of Aurem, independent submission, outer districts, Sector Seven, first (TL). Selected second by the Governor-Prelate after ranking first. The woman he picked first withdrew the night before departure, for what was called a family health emergency, and it wasn't one (TR). |
| AT THE ASSESSMENT | Her toe rests exactly behind the gold tile that separates candidates from everyone else. Asked about it: "They let me through the door. Figured the floor came with it." A nail she'd hammered flat that morning rises through the cardboard into her stocking while the board's read, and she stays where she is. Her eyes go to the bottom of the board first, to Domestic Service, Binding and Remedial, before she looks up (DR3). |
| WHAT SHE STUDIES | The Anointed Court wives, by name, relationship and known preference, for three years (CR). The Arrangement, which Celeste told her about (CR). She can't study Lyris, because Lyris has spent thirty years making sure there's nothing to study (CR). |
| WHY SHE ENTERED | For her family, and for the girls in the outer districts who'll watch the boards and need to see her name on them (TR). Partly to be somewhere useful before a Crown education officer reaches Solomon (MEN). |
| OPEN QUESTION | Which track did her Designation put her on? Eligibility asks for "Unbound or elevated designation" (TR). |

WHAT SHE ACTUALLY DOES ALL DAY IN AURELIA, HOURS, ROOMS AND HANDS

# WHAT SHE BELIEVES

TKC: TR · TL · DR3 · DOM

VOL. I · 509 · 513 · 518 · 572

| | |
|---|---|
| WHAT SHE BELIEVES | Celeste taught her that how you treat people who can't help you is the truest thing about you, and Eden holds it as faith more than strategy (TR). Her faith is real, and it "required more maintenance" than Maribel Vale's (DR3). |
| WHAT SHE ALSO BELIEVES | For women like her, the only road to the kind of power that changes things runs through a man willing to let her stand behind him while she works. Celeste taught her that, the Salt Ceremony teaches it, and the Empire confirms it (TR). |
| WHO TAUGHT HER | Celeste, at the kitchen table (TL). Miriam gave her a word from the Psalms and left (TL). |
| WHAT SHE CAN RECITE | Enough to post the highest Doctrinal Assessment score in the Trials' history, on the most complex set of questions the Vowed have built in eleven cycles (TR). |
| WHAT SHE'D SAY IN PUBLIC | Her Testimony, delivered without a handler: a statement of faith in women's intelligence worded so precisely in theological language that flagging it would mean flagging the theology (TR). |
| WHAT SHE'D BE ARRESTED FOR | The house name. The real name of the city (TL). |

### WHAT THE TEMPLE TEACHES ABOUT A WOMAN LIKE HER

Self-nomination is framed as "exceptional faith," and the process is built to exhaust anyone without backing (TR). When a candidate's intelligence becomes the story instead of her compliance, the Broadcast calls it the Eve problem and runs a narrative that "implies" and never accuses (TR). Bell prayed that God would close every door not intended for her (DR3).

### HOW SHE PRAYS: THE WORDS, THE POSTURE, AND WHERE

WRITING

FROM THE FACING PAGE

**HOW SHE PRAYS: THE WORDS, THE POSTURE, AND WHERE**

# The text

GEN 2–3

PS 46

HAB 3

ESTH 4.14

GEN 38

PROV 31.29

LUKE 1.52

JUDG 4.4

ROM 16.1–7

GEN 3.6

| | |
|---|---|
| EDEN | The garden of Genesis 2–3. **CONTESTED** The Hebrew *'eden* sounds like "delight," and some scholars connect the name to an older word for a plain or steppe. |
| SELAH | Seventy-one times in the Psalms and three in Habakkuk. The timeline says it means "pause" (**TL**), the usual gloss. **CONTESTED** Nobody knows what it meant. It's probably a musical or liturgical marker. |
| EVE · GENESIS 3 | **POSSIBLE** The Broadcast's own name for her problem (**TR**). **Where it breaks:** Eve is never asked what she wanted. Eden is asked constantly, on camera, and graded on the answer (Vol. I, 383). |
| ESTHER | **POSSIBLE** A young woman taken in a state search, prepared for months, who goes in unsummoned. **Where it breaks:** Esther is taken and told to hide her people. Eden filed the paperwork herself and paid ten dollars to be searched. |
| TAMAR · GENESIS 38 | **POSSIBLE** A woman with no standing who collects evidence instead of accusing. **Where it breaks:** Tamar had a law on her side that wasn't being enforced. Eden's law is against her (Vol. I, 419). |

| SHE'D QUOTE | NEVER READ TO HER IN THE TEMPLE |
|---|---|
| Esther 4.14, "for such a time as this," knowing the Empire quotes it too | Judges 4.4, Deborah judging Israel with no emergency offered as an excuse |
| Luke 1.52, "He hath put down the mighty from their seats" | Romans 16.1–7, Phoebe the deacon and Junia among the apostles |
| | Genesis 3.6, "her husband with her," standing there the whole time |

Proverbs 31.29 was read over her before the scores, in King James wording (**DR3**).

> **VOLUME ONE**
>
> Eve, 370. Tamar, 373. Esther and the woman of worth, 386. Deborah, 376. Mary's song, 390. The two beginnings, 242. Psalms, 121. The Lord's Prayer, 415. The Covenant Trials, 542.

TKC: DR3 · TR · TL

# Body and fear

| | |
|---|---|
| WHAT THE RECORD SHOWS | The nail through the cardboard into her stocking, and she doesn't move. Ten of her eleven dollars, counted by a clerk who inspects both sides of every bill. She walks home in the same shoes and says nothing until Celeste finds the receipt (**DR3**). |
| HOW SHE ARRIVES | She looks at the city before she looks at the cameras, carries her own bag, and walks Sovereign Boulevard slower than the choreography, like a woman who means to walk it (**TR**). The Broadcast uses forty-seven seconds of it (**TR**). |
| WHAT FEAR DOES | Fear sends her eyes to the bottom of the board first (**DR3**). **INTERPRETATION** Her ambition is defensive before it's aspirational. |
| WHAT SHE'S AFRAID IS TRUE | **INFERENCE** The road through a man is the Empire's design and not a loophole in it. If that's true, using it makes her the Empire's best argument. |

### WHAT HER BODY DOES WHEN SHE LIES, AND WHAT IT DOES WHEN SHE'S BELIEVED

### WHAT SHE'D DO IF SHE KNEW IT WAS TRUE AND HAD ONE NIGHT TO ACT

# Belief arc

TKC: TR · DR3 · CR · TL

YOURS

Faith rarely dies in one scene. It gets renegotiated four or five times, and one morning she notices. Put a chapter in the last column every time, because a station without a chapter is an intention and not a plot.

| STATION | WHAT SHE BELIEVES | WHAT CRACKS IT, AND WHAT SHE DOES | CH. |
|---|---|---|---|
| I · Inherited | The truth, delivered correctly, is the most powerful thing a person can offer in a room full of performers (TR) | Bell asks about her father instead of her grades and prays a door shut (DR3) | |
| II · First crack | The process can be beaten by someone who reads the small print | The gap between what she does in the debates and what the scores give her for it is consistent (TR) | |
| III · Collapse | | | |
| IV · What replaces it | | | |

INFERENCE The Arrangement is the first thing in the Crownward that gives her hope, because the system has a door in it nobody put on the map (CR). Decide whether that door holds.

### THE LAST THING SHE LETS GO OF

### WHO NOTICES SHE'S CHANGED, AND WHEN

TKC: TR · TL · CR · MEN · WR · FR 13

# Names, not roles

**CONTENT NOTE** Endurance violence (Maren).

| PERSON | WHAT PASSES BETWEEN THEM | LEVERAGE |
|---|---|---|
| CELESTE | Everything she knows about faith (**TL**) | |
| SOLOMON | She entered partly to protect him, and doesn't know about the teacher notes (**MEN**) | |
| SERA MONTOYA | Four words in a hallway after the Forum, and an ally who's decided two clear-eyed women beat one (**TR**) | |
| ZARA VOSS | **INTERPRETATION** The name exchange in the middle of the book (Vol. I, 553) | |
| LYRIS VANE | Eleven minutes at the Anointed Evening. The third thing is a warning that's also instructions (**TR**). | Lyris's |
| JUDAH | Thirty minutes. "Most candidates tell me they feel called." "I know." (**TR**) | |
| DELIA CROSS | Votes with her in the Forum and in the Social Policy debate (**TL**) | |
| MAREN COLE | Knocked unconscious on Endurance Day 3 and left behind (**TR**) | |
| HANNAH · ABIGAIL | The House Mother who knows the camera gaps (**TL**). The advisor who reads her for a living (**TL**). | |

**THE ONE PERSON WHO KNOWS WHAT SHE ACTUALLY BELIEVES, AND HOW THEY FOUND OUT**

# Her voice

TKC: DR3 · TR · WR 6–10 · WR 33–37

| | |
|---|---|
| ON THE PAGE | "They let me through the door. Figured the floor came with it." (**DR3**) |
| TO THE HEIR | Asked why she entered, she says she wants access to the kind of power that changes things, plainly, without theology, and watches what he does with it. "Most candidates tell me they feel called." "I know." (**TR**) |
| THE RULES | Eden narrates only what she knows, sees, hears, suspects or feels in the moment. She notices behavior before meaning, and her silence always does work (**WR 6–10**). She never "had no answer" (**WR**). |
| WITH JUDAH | Attention before desire. She doesn't talk to him in a watched room, and she doesn't understand him early (**WR 33–35**). |

### LINES ONLY EDEN WOULD SAY

### THE FOUR WORDS SHE SAYS TO SERA IN THE HALLWAY

### HOW SHE SPEAKS WITH NO RANK IN THE ROOM

TKC: TR · CR

WRITING

# THE CONTRADICTION

**CONTENT NOTE** Violence during Endurance.

| | |
|---|---|
| WHAT SHE BELIEVES AND BREAKS | **INFERENCE** How you treat people who can't help you is the truest thing about you (**TR**). On Endurance Day 3, with Delphine, she knocks Maren unconscious and leaves her in Mountain terrain (**TR**). |
| CONFLICT | The fates table has Delphine extracted with a head injury on Day 1 and helping on Day 3 (**TR**). One of the two has to move. |
| WHAT SHE WANTS AND USES | She wants to be the woman the city pauses for, and to use the pause (**CR**). The pause runs through the Empire's own machinery. |

### HOW SHE JUSTIFIES IT TO HERSELF

### WHO PAYS FOR THE JUSTIFICATION, AND THE SCENE WHERE IT LANDS

# The machinery around her

Six systems are pressing on Eden before she says a word in chapter one. You built all six, and this page holds them together so you don't stop drafting to look.

The Designation flagged her at eighteen, so she's spent three years entering every room as a file that's already open (TL). Self-nomination cost six months and ten dollars, and the Empire will read her ambition as pride the moment it stops being useful (TR, DR3). The Salt Ceremony's theology, survive by keeping part of yourself unregistered, is about to be tested at Imperial scale (DOM). Solomon's scores are coming, and she doesn't know about the notes (MEN). Leah is under the Commonwife timeline, and Eden's win is the only exit anyone in the family can see (MEN). The Broadcast holds forty percent of the score and has a name ready for a woman whose intelligence becomes the story (TR). The thing that got her to the Crownward is what they'll use to take it back.

TL TR MEN

**SIX PRESSURES**

The flag, the fee, the salt water, Solomon, Leah and the Eve problem.

**MARGINALIA**

✣ *See also:* Vol. I, scoring and the Eve problem, 555.

TKC: DR3

WRITING

# What Bell took from her

She went to a man who'd eaten Celeste's sweet potato pie for thirty-four years and asked him to sponsor her. He kept her waiting while he signed Binding certificates. He didn't ask about her grades. He asked whether her father was dead, and whether her mother was properly Bound when Eden was born. He offered Leah a Home Instruction nomination and prayed that God would close every door not intended for her. Everything after, the clause, the ten dollars and the red card, happens on the other side of that room (DR3).

**1 · WHAT SHE GENUINELY BELIEVED THAT MORNING ABOUT HOW MERIT, FAITH AND OPPORTUNITY FIT TOGETHER**

**2 · WHAT CHANGES IN HER WHILE HE ASKS ABOUT HER FATHER, AND WHAT SHE DOES WITH HER FACE**

**3 · WHAT SURVIVES THE MEETING ANYWAY, AND WHERE IT SHOWS UP LATER**

# Write her at home

WRITING

FREEWRITE

Ten minutes of Eden doing something ordinary in Celeste's house before any of it starts. No Empire, no exposition, nobody assessing her. She's been graded since she was eighteen, and there's a version of her only that kitchen has met.

If you stall: where she sits and what's wrong with that chair · what she does with her hair · what she eats when nobody's watching · the chore she hates and does anyway · what makes her petty · what makes Zion laugh · the sound of the house at nine at night.

**WRITE**

Anything here that surprised you is canon unless you cross it out. Date it.

TKC: DR3 · TL · DOM · FR 4

# Eden and Celeste

Celeste took her at two (**FR 4**), raised her on fragments of the old world, and performed the Salt Ceremony for Miriam, who left anyway. When Eden paid the ten dollars, Celeste said she'd paid for the right to be judged by people who'd already decided what she was, and cleared a shelf for her study materials by midnight (**DR3, TL, DOM**). Both halves of that woman are true, and Eden has only ever been told one of them.

**WHAT EDEN THINKS CELESTE BELIEVES ABOUT GOD, THE EMPIRE AND HER**

**WHAT CELESTE ACTUALLY BELIEVES, INCLUDING WHAT SHE'S NEVER SAID**

**THE THING EDEN HAS NEVER ASKED HER, AND THE SCENE WHERE SHE FINALLY DOES**

# What she already does

TKC: DR3

WRITING

A character reads as one continuous person when a gesture comes back changed. The left column is already on the page in Draft Three.

| ON THE PAGE | WHAT IT ESTABLISHES |
|---|---|
| Her toe exactly behind the gold tile, and the line about the floor | She tests a limit with her body, then answers with the fewest words that work |
| The nail in her stocking, and she stays put | She'll absorb pain before she gives up position, and keeps the cost private |
| The bottom of the board first | Her ambition is defensive before it's aspirational |
| Ten of eleven dollars, and the same shoes home | She pays in advance, alone, and doesn't announce it |
| The lilies, the tripod moving two feet left, Bell watching the officials | Her intelligence lives in what she catalogs |

**REPEAT. WHERE THE SAME MOVE LANDS AGAIN UNCHANGED, AND THE CHAPTER.**

**COMPLICATE. WHERE IT COSTS MORE THAN IT DID IN AURELIA.**

**REVERSE. WHERE SHE DOES THE OPPOSITE, AND WHAT MADE THAT POSSIBLE.**

WRITING

FROM THE FACING PAGE

**REVERSE. WHERE SHE DOES THE OPPOSITE, AND WHAT MADE THAT POSSIBLE.**

# PUT PRESSURE ON THE BELIEF

Take one thing Eden believes and build the room that tests it. A belief that never meets someone who wants something else is a theme and not a story.

| THE SCAFFOLD |
| --- |
| The belief, in her words |
| Who can challenge it |
| A room she can't leave |
| Who else is watching, and for whom |
| What the other person wants |
| What she wants |
| What she says |
| What she won't say |

**ROUGH THE SCENE. DIALOGUE ONLY IS FINE.**

☐ POSSIBLE ☐ OPEN QUESTION ☐ DECIDED

LOG NO. _____ DATE _____

NOTES

## ANYTHING EDEN'S DOSSIER STARTED AND DIDN'T FINISH



PORTRAIT · MIRIAM OSEI · AS CELESTE LAST SAW HER, OR AS SHE IS NOW

TKC: TL · DOM · FR 0 · FR 3 · FR 6–9 · FR 15–18

VOL. I · 388 · 527

PART I · DOSSIER 3 · ◈

# MIRIAM

*She may have fully meant to come back. Celeste heard the instability under the promise. She didn't leave indifferent. She made a promise she eventually failed to keep* ***(FR 8)****.*

### ON THE RECORD

Miriam Osei, born 2062, Bound at twenty to Thomas Osei. Reassigned after he left. Gone from Aurelia since 2090, registration deactivated, no forwarding Dominion logged (**TL, FR 0**).

### STILL OPEN

How reassignment worked, why Solomon kept the Osei name, who intercepted her letter, and what she says when she walks back in (**FR 0, FR 16**).

TKC: TL · DOM · FR 0 · FR 1

VOL. I · 525 · 527

OPEN QUESTION

# THE FILE THAT STOPPED

## Binding Registration

REGISTRY · AUREM · 2082

CROWN AND TEMPLE COPIES · WITNESSED BY A VOWED OFFICIANT

| | |
|---|---|
| NAME OF RECORD | *PARISH-OSEI, Miriam (INFERENCE from the Aurem custom)* |
| BORN | *2062 · Aurelia* |
| DESIGNATION | *Commonwife, a registration status* **(FR 1)** |
| BOUND TO | *Osei, Thomas · service sector* |
| REASSIGNED | *after 2084 · household of _____* **(FR 0)** |
| CHILDREN | *Eden, Leah, Zion · Solomon* **(FR 0)** |
| 2090 | *deactivated · no forwarding Dominion logged* |

DEACTIVATED

| NAME | WHO USES IT | WHAT IT DOES TO HER |
|---|---|---|
| MIRIAM | Celeste, never lightly **(TL)** | |
| WHAT THE CHILDREN CALL HER | Eden, Leah, Zion and Solomon | |
| COMMONWIFE | The Registry | A status, and the thing that let her be moved to another man's house **(FR 0–1)** |

**OPEN QUESTION** Does the hyphenated Binding surname apply only in Aurem, and what did Miriam's name become after reassignment (Vol. I, 525)?

# Her years against the Empire's

TKC: TL · DOM · FR 0 · FR 3–9 · FR 11 · FR 15–18

| YEAR | AGE | HER LIFE | SOURCE |
|---|---|---|---|
| 2062 | 0 | Born to Celeste, raised alone under Unbound designation, watching her mother work the Empire "with precision and exhaustion" | TL |
| 2082 | 20 | The Salt Ceremony, then her Binding to Thomas. She believes she loves him, and she does. | TL, DOM |
| 2083 | 21 | Eden. She gives her the Selah. | TL |
| 2084 | 22 | Leah. Thomas leaves for another Dominion, another woman, another life. She's reassigned to another man's household. | FR 0, FR 3 |
| 2085 | 23 | Zion, conceived before Thomas left. Eden goes to Celeste. | FR 0, FR 4 |
| 2088 | 26 | Solomon, by the man she was reassigned to | FR 0, FR 11 |
| 2090 | 28 | Leaves all four with Celeste and goes alone, to look for her father | FR 6–7, FR 17 |
| 2094 | 32 | One letter, intercepted before it reaches Celeste | FR 16 |
| | | Finds her father, Crownward-resident and close to the Vanes | FR 7, FR 17 |
| | | The arrangement that kept her unreachable ends, and she comes back. **OPEN QUESTION** In this book or book two? | FR 18 |

**SUPERSEDED** The timeline calls 2084 a disappearance that Celeste "always believed otherwise" about. Thomas left voluntarily, and the record was accurate (**FR 3**).

### THE YEAR IN HER FATHER'S HOUSEHOLD SHE'D NEVER DESCRIBE TO HER CHILDREN

WRITING

FROM THE FACING PAGE

## THE YEAR IN HER FATHER'S HOUSEHOLD SHE'D NEVER DESCRIBE TO HER CHILDREN

# The clerk's version and the true one



**CONTENT NOTE** Abandonment and coerced reassignment.

| | |
|---|---|
| ON THE LEDGER | Commonwife registration quietly deactivated in 2090, no forwarding Dominion logged (**TL**). Within four years of her Binding she was "unrecognizable to her own mother" (**TL**). |
| IN 2084 | Thomas left voluntarily, and she was reassigned to another man's household (**FR 0**, **FR 3**). **OPEN QUESTION** Who decided it, and what was her status while it happened (Vol. I, 527)? |
| WHAT SHE PROTECTED THEM FROM | The household she'd been reassigned to, and the instability of dragging four children on a search. She hadn't found her father yet, so she couldn't have named him as the threat (**FR 9**). |
| UNREACHABLE | Being unreachable wasn't selective. No version existed where she was hidden from her father and available to her children (**FR 15**). |
| HER FATHER'S HOUSE | He'd been Crownward-resident and close to the Vanes the whole time, and surviving an unregistered ceremony wasn't an oversight. He was useful to somebody, and her children would be too (**FR 17**). |

**WHAT HER DAYS WERE LIKE IN THE REASSIGNED HOUSEHOLD, AND THE MOMENT SHE DECIDED TO GO**

TKC: TL · DOM · FR 8 · FR 18

VOL. I · 509 · 513 · 527

# WHAT SHE BELIEVES

| | |
|---|---|
| WHO TAUGHT HER | Celeste, who refused every term the Empire offered and raised her to do the same (TL). The Salt Ceremony the night before her Binding: what to hold, what to hide, what not to hand over (DOM). |
| WHAT SHE BELIEVED AT TWENTY | She loved Thomas, and she did (TL). INFERENCE That love could be a private thing inside a public registration. |
| WHAT SHE GAVE AWAY | *Selah*, from the Psalms, to her first daughter (TL). INFERENCE She knew the Psalms well enough to choose from them. |
| WHAT SHE BELIEVES NOW | OPEN QUESTION The files give her conviction and no expectation of being believed when she returns (FR 18), and nothing about God. |

**WHAT THE TEMPLE TEACHES ABOUT A WOMAN LIKE HER**

A Commonwife is expected to bear children on the Covenant timeline (MEN), and an abandoned one can be moved to another household (FR 0). POSSIBLE The Temple cites Psalm 68.6, "God setteth the solitary in families," as the warrant for reassignment, and stops before the rest of the verse, "he bringeth out those which are bound with chains." For a mother who leaves, it has Titus 2.4–5, "to love their children... keepers at home."

**WHAT MIRIAM WOULD SAY TO GOD IF SHE BELIEVED HE WAS LISTENING, AND WHAT SHE'D SAY IF SHE DIDN'T**

# The text

| | |
|---|---|
| HER NAME | Miriam the prophet, the first woman the Torah calls one (Exod 15.20). Mariam in Greek, so every Mary in the New Testament (Vol. I, 388). |
| MIRIAM AT THE RIVER · EXODUS 2 | **POSSIBLE** If the unnamed sister at the river is Miriam, as tradition holds, she watches from a distance as her brother is placed in the reeds, then arranges for their own mother to nurse him. **Where it breaks:** The biblical Miriam stays near the child she placed. This one placed hers and went out of reach. |
| NUMBERS 12 | **POSSIBLE** Struck and put outside the camp for seven days, and the camp doesn't move until she's brought back. **Where it breaks:** Whether anyone in the Empire waits for this one is the question (Vol. I, 388). |
| NAOMI · RUTH 1.20–21 | **POSSIBLE** "I went out full, and the LORD hath brought me home again empty." Call me Mara. **Where it breaks:** Naomi comes home to people who recognize her. Miriam comes home to four children who've each kept a different version of the day she left (**FR 11**). |

| SHE'D QUOTE | NEVER READ TO HER |
|---|---|
| Exodus 15.21, "Sing ye to the LORD," the song her name carries | Micah 6.4, where God names Miriam with Moses and Aaron as the three he sent |
| Ruth 1.21, coming home empty | Numbers 20.1–2, her death and the next line, "there was no water" |
| | Isaiah 49.15, "Can a woman forget her sucking child... yet will I not forget thee" |

> **VOLUME ONE**
>
> Miriam, 375. Numbers, Miriam and Aaron, 152. The sea, the song and Miriam, 282. Exodus, six women, 272. Ruth and Naomi, 391 and 109. Commonwives and reassignment, 512.

EXOD 2.1–10

EXOD 15.20–21

NUM 12

NUM 20.1–2

MIC 6.4

RUTH 1.20–21

PS 68.6

ISA 49.15

TKC: TL · FR 8–9 · FR 18

# Body and fear

| | |
|---|---|
| WHAT THE RECORD SHOWS | Unrecognizable to her own mother within four years of her Binding (**TL**). Four births in five years (**TL, FR 0**). |
| WHAT SHE WAS AFRAID OF | The reassigned household, and dragging four children through a search (**FR 9**). Whether she was also protecting them from herself stays open for her later development (**FR 9**). |
| HOW SHE COMES BACK | With conviction and no expectation of being believed (**FR 18**). |

### WHAT FOURTEEN YEARS HAVE DONE TO HER BODY, HER HANDS AND HER VOICE

### WHAT SHE'S AFRAID IS TRUE ABOUT WHAT SHE DID

# Belief arc

TKC: TL · FR 3 · FR 6–9 · FR 17–18

YOURS

| STATION | WHAT SHE BELIEVES | WHAT CRACKS IT, AND WHAT SHE DOES | CH. |
|---|---|---|---|
| I · At twenty | She loves Thomas, and that's enough to live inside a Binding (TL) | He leaves voluntarily, and she's reassigned (FR 0, FR 3) | |
| II · After Thomas | She has to protect the children from the house she's in (FR 9) | She leaves all four with Celeste and goes looking for her father (FR 6–7) | |
| III · Her father's house | | The arrangement that kept her unreachable ends (FR 18) | |
| IV · The return | | | |

### WHAT SHE BELIEVED ABOUT HER FATHER BEFORE SHE FOUND HIM, AND AFTER

### WHO NOTICES SHE'S CHANGED WHEN SHE WALKS BACK IN, AND WHAT THEY SEE FIRST

TKC: TL · FR 0 · FR 3 · FR 11–18

# Who she can move, and who can move her

| PERSON | WHAT PASSES BETWEEN THEM | LEVERAGE |
|---|---|---|
| CELESTE | The Salt Ceremony, and a promise Celeste heard the instability under (**DOM, FR 8**) | |
| THOMAS | A Binding she believed in, and a man who left for another life (**TL, FR 3**) | |
| THE MAN SHE WAS REASSIGNED TO | Solomon's father. How it worked and what it meant to her are deferred (**FR 0**). | |
| HER FATHER | Crownward-resident, close to the Vanes. He knows there are children but not how many or their names, and learned about Eden the day the Trial went public (**FR 17–18**). | His |
| EDEN | Given a task to get her out of the room (**FR 13**) | |
| LEAH | Watched her pack, and defends her to the others (**FR 11, 14**) | |
| WHOEVER STOPPED THE LETTER | 2094, intercepted before it reached Celeste (**FR 16**) | |

Whether each child forgives her isn't decided, and they may land differently (**FR 6**).

### WHO INTERCEPTED THE LETTER, AND WHAT IT SAID

# Her voice

TKC: FR 18

WRITING

Nothing of Miriam's is on the page yet. Her voice is the one you'll build from nothing, and the reader will hear it through four children who each remember it differently.

### WHAT SHE SOUNDED LIKE AT TWENTY, IN CELESTE'S KITCHEN, THE NIGHT OF THE SALT CEREMONY

### WHAT SHE SOUNDS LIKE AT FORTY-TWO, SAYING SHE'S COME BACK

### THE WORDS SHE WON'T USE FOR THE MAN SHE WAS REASSIGNED TO

### LINES ONLY SHE WOULD SAY

WRITING

FROM THE FACING PAGE

## LINES ONLY SHE WOULD SAY

# The contradiction

TKC: FR 6–9 · FR 15

WRITING

| | |
|---|---|
| WHAT SHE BELIEVES AND BREAKS | **INFERENCE** She left to protect them, and the leaving was the harm (**FR 8–9**). |
| WHAT IT COST | A year of "she's coming back," then nothing said and nothing put in its place (**FR 12**). Leah's anger, and Leah's loyalty (**FR 14**). |
| WHAT THE FILES LEAVE OPEN | Whether she was also protecting them from herself (**FR 9**). |

### HOW SHE JUSTIFIES IT TO HERSELF, AT FORTY-TWO

### THE SCENE WHERE IT LANDS ON HER, AND WHO SAYS IT TO HER FACE

FR 0 | FR 15–18

**BOOK TWO**

Her father is the only person watching the Trial who understands what he's looking at (FR 18).

**MARGINALIA**

# The machinery around her

The Empire never had to remove Miriam. It only had to file her. A Commonwife is a registration status (FR 1), and a status can be moved. When her husband left, the system that had approved her Binding reassigned her to another man's household (FR 0, FR 3).

There's also the registration itself, deactivated without a forwarding Dominion (TL), so on paper she simply stops. Her father's household sits in the Crownward, close to the Vanes, where a man who survived an unregistered ceremony is useful to somebody (FR 17). Someone stopped her one letter (FR 16). And her return is triggered by something she doesn't control: the arrangement that kept her unreachable ended (FR 18). INTERPRETATION Every piece of her story is somebody else's paperwork, which is why her return has to be the first thing she does on her own authority.

✣ *See also:* Vol. I, Commonwives and reassignment, 512.

# The day she left, from her side

TKC: FR 8 · FR 11–13

WRITING

**CONTENT NOTE** A mother leaving her children.

Leah watched her pack. Eden was told to take Zion outside. Solomon was two (**FR 11**). She said she was coming back, and she may have meant it (**FR 8, FR 12**).

### 1 · WHAT SHE PACKED, AND WHAT SHE LEFT ON PURPOSE

### 2 · WHAT SHE SAID TO EDEN WHEN SHE GAVE HER THE TASK, AND WHAT SHE COULDN'T SAY

### 3 · THE LAST THING SHE SAW OF THE HOUSE

WRITING

FREEWRITE

# Write her in her father's house

Ten minutes of Miriam on an ordinary day in her father's household, years after 2090. Nobody explains anything. Somebody's watching, and she knows it.

If you stall: what she's allowed to touch · the window she stands at · what she does on her children's birthdays · what she calls her father to his face · what she writes and doesn't send · the sound of the Crownward at nine at night.

**WRITE**

# Miriam and Leah

TKC: FR 11 · FR 14 · MEN

Leah remembers a decision more than a disappearance, which is why she's the angriest and why she defends Miriam to the others (FR 14). Leah is now a Commonwife herself, under the timeline her mother lived under (MEN).

### WHAT MIRIAM THINKS LEAH SAW WHILE SHE PACKED

### WHAT LEAH ACTUALLY SAW, AND WHAT SHE'S TOLD HERSELF SINCE

### THE FIRST CONVERSATION BETWEEN THEM WHEN MIRIAM COMES BACK

WRITING

SCENE LAB

# Put pressure on the belief

| THE SCAFFOLD |
| --- |
| The belief, in her words |
| Who can challenge it |
| A room she can't leave |
| Who else is listening, and for whom |
| What the other person wants |
| What she wants |
| What she says |
| What she won't say |

**ROUGH THE SCENE. DIALOGUE ONLY IS FINE.**

☐ POSSIBLE ☐ OPEN QUESTION ☐ DECIDED

LOG NO. _____ DATE _____

NOTES

## ANYTHING MIRIAM'S DOSSIER STARTED AND DIDN'T FINISH

TKC: TL · MEN · DR3 · FR 2–3

VOL. I · 507

PORTRAIT · THOMAS OSEI · AS HE WAS IN 2082

PART I · DOSSIER 4 · ◈ · SHORT

# THOMAS

*Sometimes the paperwork is correct and a man simply leaves (**FR 3**).*

**ON THE RECORD**

Thomas Osei, a common laborer in Aurelia's service sector. Bound to Miriam in 2082. Father of Eden, Leah and Zion (**FR 2**). Left in 2084, voluntarily, for another Dominion, another woman, another life (**FR 3**).

**RULED OUT**

He wasn't removed, imprisoned or secretly killed. The Empire's record that he relocated was accurate, and it left out his reasons (**FR 3**).

# The record and the man

TKC: TL · MEN · DR3 · FR 3

VOL. I · 505 · 507

## Relocation Authorization

CROWN · LABOR ALLOCATION · 2084

MOVEMENT BETWEEN DOMINIONS REQUIRES CROWN AUTHORIZATION

| | |
|---|---|
| NAME | *OSEI, Thomas · common designation* |
| ASSIGNMENT | *Aurelia · service sector, maintenance and infrastructure* **(MEN)** |
| HOUSEHOLD OF RECORD | *Commonwife Miriam · three children* |
| DESTINATION | _____ *Dominion* |
| REASON GIVEN | *work* |

RELOCATED

| | |
|---|---|
| WHAT THE RECORD SAYS | He relocated to another Dominion for work (**TL**). It's accurate (**FR 3**). |
| WHAT IT LEAVES OUT | Another woman and another life (**FR 3**). |
| INFERENCE | Moving between Dominions needs Crown authorization, "technically available and practically difficult" (**MEN**). Somebody approved a common man leaving a Commonwife and three children, and the approval is on file. |
| THE FAMILY'S VERSION | Celeste wrote "deceased" on a form's authority line (**DR3**). Bell asked Eden whether her father was dead (**DR3**). **INTERPRETATION** Celeste's word is a verdict, not a fact. |

**SUPERSEDED** "Thomas Osei Disappears" and "Celeste has always believed otherwise" (**TL**). Every page framing 2084 as an Empire disappearance is out (FR, sweep 1).

JOHN 11.16

JOHN 14.5

JOHN 20.24–29

1 TIM 5.8

VOL. I · 415 · 417 · 507

# Faith and scripture

| | |
|---|---|
| WHAT HE BELIEVED | **OPEN QUESTION** Nothing in the files. He married a woman raised to refuse everything, which says something about one of them. |
| WHAT THE TEMPLE TEACHES ABOUT A MAN LIKE HIM | Common men are told they're free, and the control sits in housing and work (**MEN**). **POSSIBLE** The Temple preaches 1 Timothy 5.8 to common men, that a man who doesn't provide for his own house "hath denied the faith." The Crown still signed his relocation. |
| HIS NAME | Thomas, one of the twelve, called Didymus, "the twin" (John 11.16). He's the one who says "Let us also go, that we may die with him" (11.16), and "we know not whither thou goest" (14.5). |
| WHERE IT BREAKS | The apostle doubts and comes back to the room, and the story ends with him there (John 20.24–29). Thomas Osei left the room and stayed gone. His son Zion works in the same category of labor and doesn't know it (**MEN**). |

| HE'D QUOTE | NOBODY EVER READ HIM |
|---|---|
| | 1 Timothy 5.8, on providing for his own house |
| | Malachi 2.14, "the wife of thy youth, against whom thou hast dealt treacherously" |

Volume One: the men of the New Testament, 402. The names in the cast, 404. Men, labor and the economy, 492.

# Who he left

TKC: TL · FR 0 · FR 2–3 · FR 13 · MEN

| PERSON | WHAT PASSES BETWEEN THEM |
|---|---|
| MIRIAM | A Binding she believed in, and a man she did love (TL) |
| EDEN | One year old when he left (TL). Carries his name. |
| LEAH | Born the year he left (INFERENCE) |
| ZION | Conceived before he left, born after, with no memory of him (FR 0). Works in his category of labor without knowing it (MEN). |
| THE OTHER WOMAN | Another Dominion, another life (FR 3) |

DECIDED No expansion of Thomas's later life this pass (FR 3). The page below is for when you want one.

### WHAT HE'D SAY IF ONE OF HIS CHILDREN FOUND HIM

WRITING

# Write the morning he left

Ten minutes, from his side or Miriam's. The paperwork's already approved.

**WRITE**

☐ POSSIBLE ☐ OPEN QUESTION ☐ DECIDED

LOG NO.

DATE



PORTRAIT · LEAH OSEI · TWENTY · COMMONWIFE

TKC: MEN · TL · DR3 · FR 11 · FR 14 · RULING

VOL. I · 523 · 527

PART I · DOSSIER 5 · ◈

# LEAH

*She believes in Eden completely. She has always believed in Eden completely. She just needs Eden to come home (**MEN**).*

### ON THE RECORD

Leah Osei, twenty, Eden's younger sister. A Commonwife for almost two years, with no pregnancy, under the eye of the Vowed officer who runs the quarterly household assessment (**MEN**). She sat for an assessment (DECIDED).

### STILL OPEN

Her husband's name, her Binding name, what Home Instruction is, and what she does when the Broadcast turns on her sister.

TKC: MEN · DR3 · DOM · RULING

VOL. I · 523 · 525 · 527

# THE QUARTERLY FILE

**CONTENT NOTE** Pressure to conceive, and a household assessed on it.

## Household Assessment

TEMPLE · AUREM · QUARTERLY

COMMONWIFE HOUSEHOLD · CONDUCTED BY THE ASSIGNED VOWED OFFICER

| | |
|---|---|
| COMMONWIFE | *OSEI, Leah · Bound c. 2102* |
| HUSBAND | *common man · service sector · _____* |
| COVENANT TIMELINE | *two years · no conception recorded* |
| OFFICER'S REMARK | *informal · not yet filed* **(MEN)** |
| HUSBAND'S REMARK | *the same, less carefully* **(MEN)** |
| ASSESSMENT, AT EIGHTEEN | *sat · Home Instruction offered the following year* **(DR3)** |

UNDER REVIEW

| NAME | WHO USES IT | WHAT IT DOES TO HER |
|---|---|---|
| LEAH OSEI | The Registry, before her Binding | |
| HER BINDING NAME | The Registry now (Vol. I, 525) | |

**CONFLICT** The timeline has her already "living under Temple review." Men in the Empire has the officer making informal comments and no formal note yet. **INFERENCE** The review is coming, and it hasn't been filed.

# Her years against the Empire's

TKC: MEN · TL · FR 5 · FR 11 · FR 14 · RULING

| YEAR | AGE | HER LIFE | SOURCE |
|---|---|---|---|
| 2084 | 0 | Born, the year Thomas leaves | INFERENCE, FR 3 |
| 2090 | 6 | Watches her mother pack. Comes to Celeste's house with Zion and Solomon. | FR 5, FR 11 |
| 2090–91 | 6–7 | "She's coming back," for about a year | FR 12 |
| 2102 | 18 | Sits for an assessment, Aurem's at eighteen. Bound as a Commonwife to a man in the service sector. | DECIDED, MEN, INFERENCE |
| 2104 | 20 | Two years without a pregnancy. Twice a week at Celeste's kitchen table. Watches Eden on the boards every evening. | MEN |

**SUPERSEDED** "Eden's older sister" (**TL**). **DECIDED** Leah is younger than Eden.

### THE DAY OF HER BINDING, AND WHETHER ANYONE PERFORMED THE SALT CEREMONY FOR HER

TKC: MEN · DR3

VOL. I · 523 · 527 · 529

# The clerk's version and the true one

| | |
|---|---|
| ON THE LEDGER | A Commonwife, two years Bound, with the child quota pressure starting (MEN). |
| HER HUSBAND | A common man in Aurelia's service sector, "not cruel, not kind, simply present," who got a wife because the system said he was eligible and she was available. He expects what the Empire told him he could expect (MEN). |
| HER TWO DAYS | She comes to Celeste's twice a week under cover of helping with Solomon. She does help, and it's also the only two days she can breathe. She and Zion sit at the table and don't talk about what they can't talk about (MEN). |
| THE EVENINGS | She watches Eden's score move on the kitchen screen. When the Broadcast narrative shifts in Phase Three, something in her that's been quiet for two years goes very still and then very loud, and she doesn't let anyone in the house see (MEN). |
| HOME INSTRUCTION | At her assessment Bell offered to nominate her for Home Instruction the following year, as a consolation (DR3). OPEN QUESTION What is it? |

### WHAT HER OWN HOUSE LOOKS LIKE, AND WHAT SHE DOES THERE ON THE OTHER FIVE DAYS

# WHAT SHE BELIEVES

TKC: MEN · DR3 · FR 14

VOL. I · 509 · 527

| | |
|---|---|
| WHAT SHE BELIEVES | She believes in Eden completely (MEN). INFERENCE Her faith is in a person before it's in a doctrine. |
| WHO TAUGHT HER | Celeste, from the age of six. Before that, Miriam, and Leah remembers her mother's leaving as a decision (FR 14). |
| WHAT SHE DEFENDS | Miriam, to the others (FR 14). INTERPRETATION She's the angriest and the most loyal, and those come from the same place. |
| WHAT SHE HAS NO WORDS FOR | Being unready, because the Empire hasn't built a way to say it (MEN). |

**WHAT THE TEMPLE TEACHES ABOUT A WOMAN LIKE HER**

A Commonwife who doesn't conceive on the Covenant timeline is a household problem with a quarterly visit (MEN). POSSIBLE The Temple preaches "be fruitful, and multiply" (Gen 1.28) and 1 Timothy 2.15, "she shall be saved in childbearing," and reads Michal's "no child unto the day of her death" (2 Sam 6.23) as a sentence passed on a woman who despised her husband.

## WHAT SHE PRAYS FOR, AND WHETHER SHE WANTS IT ANSWERED

GEN 29–30

GEN 29.32

GEN 30.1

1 SAM 1

ISA 54.1

ISA 56.3–5

LUKE 11.27–28

PS 113.9

# The text

| | |
|---|---|
| HER NAME | Leah, Jacob's first wife, given to him by trickery, "tender eyed," and unloved. She bears six sons and a daughter, and names her first son saying "now therefore my husband will love me" (Gen 29.32). |
| WHERE IT BREAKS | The biblical Leah is the fertile wife. Leah Osei carries the name of the woman with children and lives the story of the sister without them. Rachel says "Give me children, or else I die" (Gen 30.1). |
| HANNAH · 1 SAMUEL 1 | POSSIBLE Provoked for years, praying with her lips moving and no sound, and taken for drunk by the priest. **Where it breaks:** Hannah's husband asks "am not I better to thee than ten sons?" Leah's husband makes the officer's comment, less carefully (MEN). |

| SHE'D QUOTE | NEVER READ TO HER IN THE TEMPLE |
|---|---|
| Genesis 29.32, if she ever let herself say it | Isaiah 54.1, "Sing, O barren, thou that didst not bear" |
| | Isaiah 56.4–5, promised to eunuchs who'd have no children: "a name better than of sons and of daughters" |
| | Luke 11.27–28, "Blessed is the womb that bare thee... Yea rather, blessed are they that hear the word of God, and keep it" |

The Temple likes Psalm 113.9, "He maketh the barren woman to keep house, and to be a joyful mother of children."

> VOLUME ONE
>
> Genesis, the women, 252. Hannah, Abigail and Michal, 380. The Binding, 510. Commonwives and the Covenant timeline, 512. Being sorted, and Leah's assessment, 508.

# Body and fear

TKC: MEN · DOM

**CONTENT NOTE** Reproductive pressure.

| | |
|---|---|
| WHAT THE RECORD SHOWS | Two years watched for a pregnancy (**MEN**). Two days a week she can breathe (**MEN**). |
| WHAT SHE DOES WITH IT | She doesn't let anyone in Celeste's house see what the Broadcast does to her (**MEN**). |
| WHAT SHE'S AFRAID WILL HAPPEN | **INFERENCE** A formal note, then Temple review, then whatever's past it (Vol. I, 530). |

**WHAT SHE'S AFRAID IS TRUE, AS OPPOSED TO WHAT SHE FEARS WILL HAPPEN**

**WHAT HER BODY DOES AT THE KITCHEN TABLE THAT ZION HAS LEARNED TO READ**

TKC: MEN · FR 14

YOURS

# Belief arc

| STATION | WHAT SHE BELIEVES | WHAT CRACKS IT, AND WHAT SHE DOES | CH. |
|---|---|---|---|
| I · At six | Her mother decided to go (FR 14) | | |
| II · Bound | INFERENCE The Binding is survivable if she can still get to the kitchen | The quota pressure starts (MEN) | |
| III · Phase Three | Eden will come home | The Broadcast's narrative turns on Eden (MEN) | |
| IV · On the last page | | | |

### WHAT SHE DOES ON THE NIGHT THE NARRATIVE SHIFTS, AFTER SHE LEAVES CELESTE'S HOUSE

### WHO SHE TELLS, IF ANYONE

# Names, not roles

TKC: MEN · DR3 · FR 11 · FR 14

| PERSON | WHAT PASSES BETWEEN THEM | LEVERAGE |
|---|---|---|
| EDEN | Complete belief (MEN) | |
| ZION | The table, and everything they don't say at it (MEN) | |
| CELESTE | The only place she still feels like herself (MEN) | |
| HER HUSBAND | What the Empire told him to expect (MEN) | His, and the officer's |
| THE VOWED OFFICER | A quarterly visit and an informal comment (MEN) | Hers |
| MIRIAM | Watched her pack. Defends her. (FR 11, 14) | |
| BELL | A consolation nomination (DR3) | |

**HER HUSBAND'S NAME, HIS WORK, AND ONE THING HE DOES THAT SURPRISES HER**

TKC: MEN · FR 14

WRITING

# Voice and contradiction

| | |
|---|---|
| THE CONTRADICTION | INFERENCE She's the angriest at Miriam and the one who defends her (FR 14). She's furious about a decision and lives inside one she didn't make. |
| WHAT IT COSTS | _ |

### LINES ONLY LEAH WOULD SAY

### WHAT SHE SAYS TO MIRIAM'S DEFENSE WHEN ZION GOES QUIET

# The machinery around her

Leah lives inside the system the Trials sit on top of. A Commonwife is a registration status (FR 1), assessed quarterly in Aurem by a Vowed officer who notices when two years pass without a pregnancy (MEN). Her husband was given a wife and told what to expect, and the Empire built no way for her to say she isn't ready (MEN).

Above her, Aurem itself made marriage look like the highest honor a woman can get, on purpose (DOM). Behind her is a mother who lived the same registration and was moved to another man's house when her husband left (FR 0). In front of her, every evening at seven, is her sister's score (TR).

MEN | DOM | FR 0–1

### THE CLOCK

Two years and counting. What happens after Temple review is still yours to decide (Vol. I, 530).

### MARGINALIA

✣ *See also:* Vol. I, Commonwives, 512.

TKC: MEN

# Leah and Zion

They sit at Celeste's table and don't talk about the things they can't talk about, and the not-talking is its own communication (MEN). He misses her in a way he has no words for and carries it as anger (MEN).

### WHAT LEAH ISN'T SAYING

### WHAT ZION ISN'T SAYING

### THE ONE EVENING IT BREAKS, AND WHAT GETS SAID

# PUT PRESSURE ON THE BELIEF

| THE SCAFFOLD |
| --- |
| The belief, in her words |
| Who can challenge it |
| A room she can't leave |
| Who else is watching, and for whom |
| What the other person wants |
| What she wants |
| What she says |
| What she won't say |

**ROUGH THE SCENE. DIALOGUE ONLY IS FINE.**

☐ POSSIBLE ☐ OPEN QUESTION ☐ DECIDED

LOG NO. _____ DATE _____

NOTES

## ANYTHING LEAH'S DOSSIER STARTED AND DIDN'T FINISH




TKC: MEN · TL · DR3 · FR 0 · FR 13 · RULING

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PART I · DOSSIER 6 · ◈ · SHORT

# Zion

*He's waiting for Eden to come back and tell him what she found. He doesn't know exactly what he's waiting for. He knows he's waiting (**MEN**).*

### ON THE RECORD

Zion Osei, eighteen (DECIDED). Common designation, labor track, Aurelia assignment, marriage eligible (**MEN**). Works maintenance and infrastructure. Lives in Celeste's house, signs its forms, and looks after Solomon (**MEN, DR3**).

### STILL OPEN

What the men told him at his Speaking, who he's expected to marry by twenty-one, and whether he ever mentions the yard.

TKC: MEN · DR3 · TL · FR 0 · FR 13 · RULING

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# The record and the man

## Covenant Declaration

CROWN OFFICE · AURELIA

REGISTERED AT EIGHTEEN · COMMON DESIGNATION

| | |
|---|---|
| NAME | *OSEI, Zion* |
| BORN | *2085 (INFERENCE) · Thomas's son (**FR 2**)* |
| TRACK | *labor · Aurelia assignment* |
| MARRIAGE | *eligible* |
| DESIGNATION SCORES | *strong, not exceptional · not flagged* |
| HOUSEHOLD AUTHORITY | *Parish household, from his eighteenth year* |

DECLARED

| | |
|---|---|
| THE WORK | Aurelia's service sector, maintenance and infrastructure, the same general category Thomas worked in. He doesn't know that, and nobody's told him (**MEN**). |
| THE HOUSE | Unmarried common men without independent housing have nowhere else to go (**MEN**). Past twenty-two it's the labor dormitory (**MEN**). |
| THE FORM | When Solomon's form came back asking for the next adult male, Zion signed. Celeste hadn't wanted him to (**DR3**). |
| THE YARD | He remembers being outside the day Miriam left and has never mentioned it (**FR 13**). |
| THE BLESSING | His scores were strong but not exceptional, so no Crown education officer came for him. It's the only thing about his Designation Celeste counts as an uncomplicated blessing (**MEN**). |

**DECIDED** Zion is eighteen (**Ruling**). **SUPERSEDED** Nineteen (**MEN**). **CONFLICT** Men in the Empire puts his Speaking "two years ago," while Eden "was already watching the trials" and away from Aurelia. At eighteen his Speaking was in 2103, and Eden was home.

# Faith and scripture

PS 137.1

ISA 62.1

ZECH 9.9

2 THESS 3.10

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| | |
|---|---|
| WHAT HE BELIEVES | **OPEN QUESTION** The files give his work, his house and his waiting, and nothing about God. **INFERENCE** He was raised at the same table as Eden. |
| WHO TAUGHT HIM | Celeste. And the men of the outer district, the night before his Declaration, each saying one true thing about being a man in Aurelia. No father, no Thomas, no Osei man at all. Celeste sat outside the room and wept, because it shouldn't have been her place and there she was again (MEN). |
| WHAT THE TEMPLE TEACHES ABOUT A MAN LIKE HIM | Service as freedom. The Empire's trick is making common men feel like the system's beneficiaries while using them to enforce it (MEN). **POSSIBLE** He hears 2 Thessalonians 3.10, "if any would not work, neither should he eat," at every labor service. |
| HIS NAME | Zion is a place before it's a person: Jerusalem's hill, and the city addressed as "daughter of Zion" (Zech 9.9). "By the rivers of Babylon, there we sat down, yea, we wept, when we remembered Zion" (Ps 137.1). |
| WHERE IT BREAKS | "For Zion's sake will I not hold my peace" (Isa 62.1). Everyone in scripture speaks for Zion. This Zion doesn't speak, and carries what he misses as anger that comes out sideways (MEN). |

Volume One: the names in the cast, 404. Men, labor and the economy, 492. The Speaking, in lived religion, 498.

### ONE TRUE THING A MAN TOLD HIM AT HIS SPEAKING

TKC: MEN · TL · DR3 · FR 13

# Who he's looking after

| PERSON | WHAT PASSES BETWEEN THEM |
|---|---|
| EDEN | He promised her he'd look after Celeste (**TL**). He's waiting for her to come back (**MEN**). |
| CELESTE | He signed the form she didn't want signed (**DR3**) |
| LEAH | Missed, with no words for it. The table and what they don't say at it (**MEN**). |
| SOLOMON | He takes care of him (**MEN**) |
| THOMAS | A man he has no memory of (**FR 0**), in the same line of work |

### WHAT MAKES ZION LAUGH

### LINES ONLY ZION WOULD SAY

# Write the night of the Speaking

WRITING

Ten minutes. The men are in the room, Zion can't speak, and Celeste is on the other side of the door.

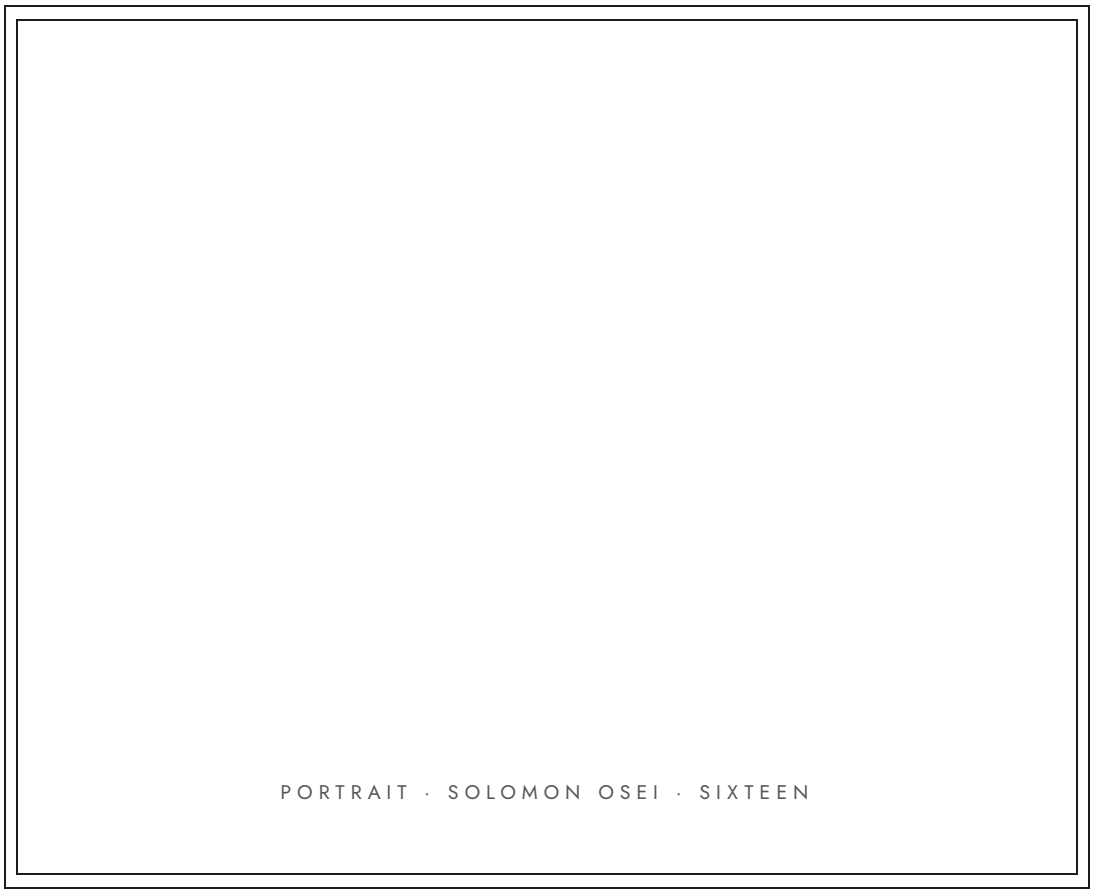
**WRITE**

☐ POSSIBLE ☐ OPEN QUESTION ☐ DECIDED

LOG NO. _____ DATE _____

TKC: MEN · TL · FR 0 · FR 11

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PART I · DOSSIER 7 · ◈ · SHORT

# Solomon

*He's doing exactly what Eden feared he would: excelling in Imperial school in the way that gets boys flagged (**MEN**).*

**ON THE RECORD**

Solomon Osei, sixteen. Designation in two years. Extraordinary theological reasoning, governance aptitude in the top percentile of his cohort, and two informal teacher notes already with the Crown education office (**MEN**). He prays over Eden before she leaves (**TL**).

**STILL OPEN**

How he kept the Osei name, what he knows about his father, and what he does when the officer knocks (**FR 0**).

# The Record and the Boy

TKC: MEN · FR 0 · FR 11 · RULING

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## Informal Note

CROWN EDUCATION OFFICE · AURELIA

FILED BY A TEACHER · NOT AN OFFICIAL FLAG

| | |
|---|---|
| STUDENT | *OSEI, Solomon · sixteen* |
| THEOLOGICAL REASONING | *extraordinary* |
| GOVERNANCE APTITUDE | *top percentile of cohort* |
| NOTES ON FILE | *two* |
| BECOMES A FLAG | *at seventeen, when the pre-Designation assessment begins* |

NOTED

| | |
|---|---|
| HIS FATHER | The man Miriam was reassigned to after Thomas left (FR 0). He was two in 2090 (FR 11). OPEN QUESTION Why did he keep the Osei name? |
| THE COACHING | Celeste is teaching him exactly how much of himself to show in which rooms, the way Red Earth mothers coach their sons. He understands what she's teaching. He's sixteen, and sometimes he forgets to hide it, and they have the conversation again (MEN). |
| THE DOOR THAT OPENS ONCE | A Crown education officer comes within three months of exceptional scores, with a scholarship to the Imperial Education Track. Declining routes a boy to the worst labor for life. Accepting makes him Crown-adjacent for life (MEN). |
| WHAT EDEN DOESN'T KNOW | The notes. She finds out in book two, and it's the moment she understands winning wasn't the end of anything (MEN). |

SUPERSEDED Thirteen (TL). DECIDED Sixteen.

2 SAM 12.24–25

1 KGS 3.9

1 KGS 5.13

1 KGS 12.4

DAN 1.3–8

1 SAM 3.10

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# Faith and scripture

| | |
|---|---|
| WHAT HE BELIEVES | He prays over his sister before she leaves (TL). INFERENCE A boy whose theological reasoning is extraordinary has been arguing with the Book of Covenant in his head for years. |
| WHO TAUGHT HIM | Celeste, and the Imperial school, which is grading him for it (MEN). |
| WHAT THE TEMPLE TEACHES ABOUT A BOY LIKE HIM | The Track is offered as opportunity and honor (MEN). POSSIBLE The officer quotes 1 Samuel 3.10, the boy in the temple who answers "thy servant heareth." |
| HIS NAME | Solomon, born to David and Bathsheba after the household broke, and named Jedidiah, "beloved of the LORD," by Nathan (2 Sam 12.24–25). Offered anything, he asks for "an understanding heart" (1 Kgs 3.9). |
| WHERE IT BREAKS | The biblical Solomon built with conscripted labor, and the north revolted over his "grievous" yoke (1 Kgs 5.13, 12.4). Solomon Osei is the boy the Crown wants to conscript. |
| DANIEL · DANIEL 1 | POSSIBLE The king orders young men "skilful in all wisdom" brought to the palace and trained for three years. It reads like the Imperial Education Track, in a story set in the sixth century BCE. **Where it breaks:** Daniel "purposed in his heart that he would not defile himself with the portion of the king's meat" (1.8). Solomon hasn't been asked yet. |

Volume One: Ezekiel and Daniel, 132. Kingmakers, prophets and priests, with Solomon, 400. Men, labor and the economy, 492.

### THE PRAYER HE PRAYS OVER EDEN, WORD FOR WORD

# Who's protecting him

TKC: MEN · TL · DR3 · FR 0

| PERSON | WHAT PASSES BETWEEN THEM |
|---|---|
| CELESTE | The coaching, again and again (**MEN**) |
| EDEN | She entered the Trials partly for him, and doesn't know about the notes (**MEN**) |
| ZION | Looks after him, and signed his form (**MEN, DR3**) |
| HIS FATHER | |
| HIS TEACHERS | Two notes (**MEN**) |

### THE THING HE SAYS IN CLASS THAT HE SHOULDN'T HAVE

### LINES ONLY SOLOMON WOULD SAY

WRITING

# Write the knock

Ten minutes. The pre-Designation assessment is a year away, and somebody from the Crown education office is at the door early.

**WRITE**

☐ POSSIBLE ☐ OPEN QUESTION ☐ DECIDED

LOG NO. _____ DATE _____

# Working Questions for the Household

YOURS

OPEN QUESTIONS

BACK MATTER LOG

**1 · WHO NAMED LEAH, ZION AND SOLOMON, AND DID CELESTE APPROVE OF THE NAMES?**

**2 · WHAT DOES THE HOUSE LOOK LIKE? DRAW THE FLOOR PLAN, AND MARK WHERE EACH PERSON SLEEPS.**

**3 · WHAT DOES THE HOUSEHOLD LIVE ON, WEEK TO WEEK, AND WHO EARNS IT?**

**4 · WHICH NEIGHBORS WERE AT ZION'S SPEAKING, AND WHICH WOMEN WOULD COME FOR CELESTE'S TELLING?**

**5 · WHAT DOES EACH CHILD CALL MIRIAM WHEN THEY TALK ABOUT HER, AND WHAT DO THEY CALL HER WHEN CELESTE CAN HEAR?**

WRITING

FROM THE FACING PAGE

**5 · WHAT DOES EACH CHILD CALL MIRIAM WHEN THEY TALK ABOUT HER, AND WHAT DO THEY CALL HER WHEN CELESTE CAN HEAR?**